Hella bad boy stories?

I realized after traveling around the world a little bit- that my childhood was in no way typical or normal. The people I told these stories too seemed to be genuinely entertained by them- most of them found the stories very funny or very disturbing- or both.

At that point I realized that the stories were pretty unique and that they could entertain people. So I wrote them down in this book so I could share them with more people.

These are true stories that came from my real life growing up in San Jose, California in the 80's and 90's.

Out in the world I'm known mostly for making strange animated full length films as I technically am an award winning internationally renowned animation filmmaker- but thats old news now.

I was a multi-cultural kid with some Croatian and Mexican genetics amongst other things- I was the "white kid" in my lower middle class neighborhood growing up though- It was a mostly Mexican neighborhood.

These are some of the stories that came out of that place. Thank you for choosing to read some of my hella bad boy stories. Sorry for all the spelling and punctuation errors, if you give a shit- I wrote this really fast and I don't give a shit.

If you enjoy these stories and want to drop me some crypto you can do so here

Bitcoin

3LWqAMxPRmJcrdRGZ5rfdRk8SESprn8MWa

Ethereum

0xc820769C9aA382C68c4361981fd53f3C8bC7f3d0

If you want to contact me you can do so at **mdotstrange@gmail.com** or on twitter @mdotstrange

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DUMPSTER PORNO

Walking home from what little of middle school you attended- you pass a dumpster- shredded paper and non threatening inorganic trash vomited out of it and onto the gravel below- one of your friends wanders over to kick around in the stuff dumped out of the dumpster in an industrial neighborhood you walk through on your way home from school-

The place where fights happen that are planned at school- they happen here- mounds of dirt, gravel, gruff concrete walls ready to shave your face off if you slid down their facade-

Your friend kicking at the trash leans over and picks something up- he stands in silencing examining some alien artifact- “what is that” you ask- he doesn’t answer staring at a meteorite or perhaps a miniature crashed flying saucer- “What is it” you ask again “ I bet its a porno”

Your other friend howls as you both run over to him standing on either side- necks cranked down staring at the soiled warped pages in his hands- tits, ass, penis, porn- reviled and fascinated your eyes dart back and forth looking for the police that are sure to slide down on wires and send you to scary prison island for life or even worse!

Your mom! -who just happened to be patrolling the premises on an anti porn debris campaign to save her little buddy from getting a boner and batin till his hand hurts.

You all stare at the images in silence as the holder of the porn slowly turns the water stained pages with a slight crackle- “what is this” you wonder “ do they really do that?

Perplexed by the porn your eyes fires back and forth as you hear some other kids approaching- your friend tosses the porn debris away and you continue home a sinner as you and your friends have just made your communion at the neighborhood catholic church-

What you have just done is surely dirty and bad and you feel as such- you're still a few years from the age when your expected to start doing it- you know- the sex- you will be obligated by law to try to put it in and do the it in a few years so the pressure isn't so bad now- you shake out the confusion and guilt and go on being a kid- you'll deal with those weird things when you get to high school-

Horrified and confused by the strange images in the magazine you must know more- in secret- no one can know that you must know about these things- I mean what if the priest found out? What if your mom found out?

I was an altar boy a few times for the local catholic church and I must say it was a pretty creepy experience- you and a few other young boys in the back of the church-

This dark, dank strange place- wearing these weird robes- commanded by these creepy old men in weirder robes- being there didn't feel right so I didn't go back after the second time- but in and around the church you were made to feel like it was some sort of special honor to be allowed to be an altar boy- like the church was doing you a favor allowing you to be an unpaid slave to some weird old men behind the curtains-

Behind the latin chanting- behind the sink of "holy water" that smelled like the sulfur spring you drank from once at the park up in the hills- behind the money basket on a stick they would hover over the crowd of people that didn't understand

anything about the latin ceremony other than when to sit, when to stand, when to put the smelly water on your head, and when to give money- fucking weird-

I ONLY BREATHE PUSSY AIR HOLMES

I just looked at the magazine though- there was one kid I remember who had some more advanced relationships with the moldy old porno mags we'd find in crusty alleys and vomited out of dumpsters in industrial areas- this kids name was Ray- he was a friend of a friend-

I went over to this friends house whose dad had a booming landscaping business made on the backs of illegal immigrants he smuggled in as he moonlit as a "coyote" He'd drive over the border- smuggle a gang of dudes in one of his campers- bring them back to his house and let them live in one of the other campers in his backyard-

He'd charge them rent to live back there with no bathrooms other than large stanky barrels with flies gathered they'd dump in the corner of the yard- they were pretty much his slaves as he'd dock their pay to reimburse him for the coyote fee + rent fee's- this guy was a real bastard of a man-

When the landscapers were all out at work during the day we'd sneak into their campers where we'd find porno magazines and one of the most disturbing things I had ever encountered in my young life-

This thing that disturbed me so was "pussy" scented incense- the illegal workers were burning "pussy" incense in their cramped camper love shacks- so many questions rushed into my young mind when I encountered this package of this pussy incense but I didn't have much time to ask them as Ray was busy with a porno magazine that he had found-

My other friend was laughing while Ray was breathing hard on top of one of the beds- I moved over to their side of the room- as I did Ray screamed out " get away " and ran out of the

camper- I looked down at the bed at a porno magazine with a hole cut out in the middle of a woman's spread legs- Ray was a bad boy-

Back to the pussy incense for a second- why would you burn pussy incense? Like you were so much of a macho, dick slangin, ball hangin man you just couldn't stand breathing anything else other than pussy smoke?

Hey man wanna breath this regular air not scented by genitals? Nah man fuck you! I don't need that bullshit! I'm a real man holmes, I only breathe pussy air vato! Now that slang was the slang of a Mexican dude from Murica of course- these dudes from Mexico wouldn't say holmes or vato and that is some Murica cholo talk.

I grew up in a neighborhood that always had gang stuff going on- so I learned the cholo talk ay but you won't find me smoking no lennies holmes- And when I breathe air holmes, its pussy air holmes- I can't be breathing that faggot ass non genital air homie.

SPERM PERM

Pornography made young boys do strange things- why? Were we doing things we thought we were supposed to do? That we had seen other people do? I'm not sure- I just know we had some really strange ideas about sex back then- this was all around the ages of 6-8-

I heard about sperm and I was pretty sure I knew what that was- that was the stuff that shot out of a man's penis that made babies- I had also heard about a perm- I didn't know what it was so I assumed it had something to do with sperm as it sounded similar- One day while playing with my best friend Bobby he cracked open his mom and dad's mattress and found a new-non moldy- non crusty porno magazine and a pack of condoms- a huge find!

So we slid the magazine out and started to flip through the pages- we stopped at one in particular- it was a naked man with his penis lathered up with soap suds for some reason- ya know porn, some people get boners from the weirdest shit- at the time we didn't know it was soap- we assumed it was sperm- the closest thing I had seen to this was clusters of frog eggs I had seen in a pond-

So this must have something to do with eggs or reproduction I thought- so eggs and sperm that had to be this perm thing I had heard about- so Bobby and I agreed that this was a "perm" What it was for we weren't sure- but it could probably make babies-

Imagine our dismay and horror when one day Bobby's mom told him that she wanted to take him to get a "perm" He looked over at me in horror "there were in style" she said- What kind of place would you go to do that? What if you didn't have

enough sperm to make a perm? Weren't we too young to sperm and have perm's?

We didn't even know how to sperm- we just assumed you had to drink a lot of milk to do so- we thought that shooting sperm was like having some kind of gun that you reloaded by drinking milk- sort of like how you got phlegm from drinking milk- sperm was like phlegm coming out of your penis and Bobby's mom wanted to take him somewhere to do that- I went home that day afraid as to what was going to happen to my friend- she told him his cousin had already got one and he liked it- what kind of a world was this?

I thought his cousin was pretty cool up to this point- but what kind of a kid was he now? Drinking all this milk and sperming onto his own head to make a perm?! It didn't make any sense but somehow frogs were related?! What the fuck?! That is childhood.

Bobby came over my house to play a few days later- his hair now a weird helmet shape that smelled like flowers-

With his hands in his pockets he kicked at the dirt " this is a perm" he said " what?!" I was stunned " yeah its a thing they do to your hair? he said " with sperm?! " I fired back- " no it doesn't have anything to do with sperm- its just some hairspray like stuff" he said " oh " I mumbled as I reached out to touch his new shiny helmet of hair that

I still thought was some how connected to that man's lathered up penis in the magazine and somehow frogs- it wasn't but I still didn't want a perm.

COCKROACH BBQ

Ray was humping porno magazines under the influence of pussy incense- He was bad but not the worst boy in my neighborhood when it came to pornography- up to that point I had never seen any porno movies- just magazines-

My friend from the other side of the block- lets call him Randy- he was a big kid who was much smaller in his own mind- he was bigger and stronger that all of us but he acted like he was tiny- he had a mom who had Cerebral Palsy- she drove around in an electric wheel chair a lot of the time even though she could walk albeit with a noticeable limp- we learned Randy's name in the neighborhood before we had even seen him-

Shortly after they moved in we heard a slurred woman's voice routinely screaming "Rrrrrandddyyyyyy" It was scary- it came at all hours of the day and night- we were all glad that we weren't Randy because that voice sounded angry- a few friends and I were crawling around the neighborhood one night crunching the large cockroaches that swarmed the street corners-

We were expert cockroaches killers- we'd step on them until that got boring- then we went into our mom's cleaning closets and started mixing chemicals together to pour them or spray them on roaches- the most effective roach killer we found was carpet cleaning foam- the roaches would get trapped in the foam- the foam would eventually dissipate with dead roach inside-

We went from chemical weapons to flame throwers- we would drop a piece of fishing line with a piece of salami on the end down the sewer grate- leave it down there for a few seconds then pull it up- it would be covered with dozens of huge roaches- one of us would steal a big can of aqua mist hair spray from one

of our chola sisters bathrooms- the fiery carnage that ensued was worth her yelling at us for wasting it- we'd pull the roaches up then hold a match out spraying it with the hair spray- a huge ball of flames would roll out with a bassy WHOOF sound torching the now fleeing roaches-

We'd then stomp out the flaming roaches or burn them some more- cars would drive by and yell at us telling us " you're going to blow up the neighborhood you god damn kids " we didn't listen as we were punk pyromaniac kids with no dad's and it was just too much fun-

We did go too far once as once as one of us found a can of gasoline which we poured down into the sewer then tossed in a lit match- ten foot high flames leapt out of the sewer as cars stopped- people screaming as we little bastards laughed- we got used to older people yelling at us from passing cars out there- they weren't our dads so we didn't listen- we didn't have dads so we did whatever the fuck we wanted! We definitely were little bastards and yes, it was fun.

THE SCARY VOICE THROWS KNIVES

So one of those nights when we were killing roaches without chemical or flame weapons we noticed the new kid and his mom in their front yard so we strolled up to the short wooden fence surrounding their front yard-

His mom said hello to us as she had a large kitchen knife in her hand using to point at places where she wanted Randy to dig and bury these little plants they had stacked in plastic pots in the corner of the yard- she yelled and pointed to where she wanted him to plant something "RANDY!" she yelled out and he was misunderstanding her commands " Where mom? I don't know?! " he gasped " RANDY!" her voice growing louder-

We watched as she cocked her arm back and threw the large kitchen knife through the air- whoosh as it stuck into the ground a few inches from his hand "THERE" she said as she looked at us and smiled- we smiled back as we where half terrified and half amazed at her knife throwing skills " she's like a ninja " I thought totally unaware at the irony that real Ninja's from Japan were gardeners by day and assassins by night-

I didn't know this at the time but if I did I would have asked Randy's mom to train me as every kid back then wanted to be a ninja- with their jump kicks and ninja stars-

After Randy buried the small plant as we watched- his mom looked over at us " Randy do you want to play with these kids? " she asked as she smiled at us " I guess so" he answered " Ok go ahead" she said " but come home when I call you " she said in a stiff tone " yes mom" he said as he flipped the latch on the gate and walked out to join us- thats the day Randy joined the kids in our neighborhood-

Randy was a good kid- he was certainly better than the rest of us- he was always on edge- at any moment his mom could scream “RRRRRANNNNDYYY!” and he’d have to go running- he could be in the middle of a sentence- in the middle of the street- in the middle of winning the olympics he’d drop everything and go running when he heard that voice-

Once we learned of this pavlovian response by Randy we’d used it against him for comedic purposes- once of us would pretend we had to go to the bathroom and walk away- we’d go somewhere where Randy couldn’t see us then scream put with our best impression of his mom “RRRRRRANDDYYYY!” He’d spring to his feet “Oh shit” he’d say and run home- coming back kicking the ground “ you guys are assholes” he’d say before we all had a laugh-

SCRIBBLE CHANNEL

Randy lived in a small house on the corner of the block- the bedrooms on his house were right on the sidewalk and they were at kid eye level- you could just stand on the sidewalk and look into his house- I was creeping around the corner stomping roaches by myself like I often did when Randy walked out of his gate- His head hung low “whats the matter?” I asked him- “ nothing- my mom just told me to leave- she’s in there with Rick” he said- Rick was a man- a Vietnam war veteran in a wheelchair that lived with them-

Randy meandered on the sidewalk outside of his house as I went back to stomping roaches- he kept walking over to one of the bedroom windows and looking in- then walking away- then back to the window- “What did he keep looking at?” I wondered so I walked over next to him and looked in the window-

Looking past the curtains on either side of the window- there was a television glowing in the middle of the room- on it was an old man having sex with a younger woman- a porno movie!-

I was frozen as I had never seen one before- it was all so weird- I didn’t want to look but then I couldn’t pull away from the window- after a few minutes of watching I began to notice the voices- the moans- with the glow of the tv in the center of the room I could see shapes moving and I could hear people talking and moaning in strange low tones- it began to creep me out and I was afraid to get caught by the police or my mom so I pulled away from the window-

I stood with Randy as we looked into each others eyes saying nothing- walking back over to the corner stepping on roaches-

I should go back and say I had sort of seen porno movies before then- our local cable service carried the Spice channel which I know now was a softcore porn channel- we called it the “scribble channel” because back then it was analog tv-

If you didn’t pay to subscribe for the Spice channel you could navigate to that channel on your TV but the picture was scrambled- you could still hear the sound but the picture was a mess of scribbles hence the name “scribble channel”

When your parents weren’t home and no one was around you’d tune into the scribble channel and listen in to the sounds of it- the sex- there were people doing it with their “oohs” and “aahs” and “oh yeahs” every once in a awhile you’d catch site of a boob or a butt -your batin moving into high gear for a few seconds until the boob or butt faded back into scribbles with you switching back to low gear batin- or shit, as a twelve year old boy is was probably all high gear super speed batin back then- oh my god a boob HIGH GEAR- oh my god a butt HIGH GEAR- oh my god I touched my own dick and its my dick?! oh my god my dick HIGH GEAR- the strange things the first doses of testosterone do to boys-

I remember back when I was 14 and on the first day of high school that I attended for a week before dropping out- they had swimming class scheduled for the first week of high school for us kids-

What a brilliant idea that was? Its freezing- your awkward and terrified in this new school- you’re perved out young boys and yep- swim class- CO-ED-

I remember almost having a seizure as he walked out to the pool and there was a girl standing just a few feet from me in

a swimsuit with a butt- a girl but was right there- yep I almost died- It was a girls butt…..HIGH GEAR!

FOOTBALL HICKEY MAKER

I wonder why I dropped out when the first thing I saw when I walked into the main hall was a large, fat 12th grade football player laughing while he pinned a tiny little freshman boy like me against the wall and gave him a hickey-

I'm not even lying- and this is not a metaphorical hickey- this sick fat fuck who the other normies assumed was a straight alpha make football player was some closeted sick fuck living out his fantasies in that hall that morning-

He did it to three or four other boys while his football friends high-fived him and they all laughed- his bulging eyes scanning the hall looking for a new victim to suck on- leaving his mark for all too see- I ducked through a hall and hid near a restroom until the bell rang as their entourage passed-

So in the first day of my limited amount of high school I almost died from seeing a girls butt then was nearly vacuumed up by some fat closeted football players disgusting lamprey like hickey making mouth-

No wonder I dropped out- also the school sucked- the teachers were a joke- the curriculum was a joke- the drivers ed teacher recently back from a suspension after banging a fifteen year old student the year before- he was in his fifties- oh yeah there was the cool- hip- young teacher who was in his mid twenties who always stayed in his classroom at lunch time- with a sixteen year old student that everyone knew he was banging- so why did I want to be in this place?

THE SCRIBBLE CHANNEL MASTER

I had sort of seen a porno but only with the help of Bobby- he was the master of deciphering the scribble channel- he was the magic man that could unlock the secrets for the rest of us- we'd sit around his TV as he opened up a panel on the front of it with various knobs used to tune the tv's reception- he'd run into the kitchen and come back with aluminum foil-

He had sculpted some kind of magic scribble canceling antennae extension with it- placing it on top of the regular antennae- he'd then tilt the TV at weird angles- all the while the boobs and butts got clearer and clearer- one step closer to the true crystal clear porno dream we'd all been waiting for-

He'd sit there hyper focused- silent- like he was cracking a safe with millions of dollars of jewels inside- there was a great treasure inside for us twelve year old boys- serious booty- wha wha whaaaaaa- bad jokes aside Bobby was a master scribble cracker after a short time we could sort of kinda see stuff better-

Instead of being a screen of colorful spaghetti scribbles it was grainy black and white blur where you could make out what was going on-

It was a great improvement from the normal scribbles but if his mom came home he'd have to scramble to re-scramble the tv or else she'd find out about her horrible son who un-scribbled the scribbles for the rest of rest-

So I'd sort of seen un scribbled scrambled porn before- nothing as clear as the images I saw in Randy's window while his mom did who knows what with Rick in that small corner house-

PUBLIC MASTURBATION BOY

Shortly after Randy moved in another new kid moved in next door to him- we knew nothing about this kid- the people that lived there before consisted of a man, his wife and their little girl-

I remember waking up several times in the middle of the night with the man screaming at the top of his lungs as if he were fighting a life and death battle with invisible enemies- they were strange and terrifying experiences to wake up in the middle of the night to the sound of that- but not so bad compared to what I had been through earlier in life-

I was told by my mom that the man was a “Vietnam Veteran” the man was quiet and kind during the day but seemed to turn into this out on control maniac late at night- the episodes would end with him sobbing as his wife tried to calm him down- that poor man- they moved away after a few months- I wonder what ever happened to them- if his nightmares ever ended-

A new kid had moved into that house- as Randy and I were standing on the corner- post first porno movie watching, the new kid popped out of his house and walked right up to us- he was barefoot wearing sweatpants and a t-shirt “ hi my names Jimmy” he said- we introduced ourselves and it got quiet for a moment “ want to see something?” Randy asked the new kid “ what?” he asked “ just go look in that window” Randy said as he pointed to our free walk up porn theater-

The kid stuck his hands in his pocket and walked up to the window- the glow of the TV lit up his face as he laughed transfixed by the scene- we watched him as he laughed and jumped up a few times- bending in half then back up straight giggling- “ ok come back over here before they see you “ Randy

whispered- the kid walked away from the window then back towards us- there was an old truck parked on the corner next to Randy's house- the kid walked up to the truck with his back to us-

Randy and I looked at each other as we could see that the kid was up to something funny- the kid had his back to us as his hands were busy doing something at the front- to our surprise and horror the kid jumped up and spun around- his erect penis out in the moonlight masturbating right there in public on the corner of our block-

Randy and I looked back and forth waiting for the police to arrive or a mom to show up but they didn't- our shock wore off as the kid proceeded to jump around giggling on the corner masturbating- he stood next to the stop sign masturbating while looking at the passing cars laughing- it was dim under the orange street lights so the people in the cars probably didn't notice him- he just kept jumping around jerking off giggling like a manic barefoot on the street corner-

SCATBO: FIRST PORN

Our other friend “Paco” the craziest of all had been let out of his house and walked up to the corner- his dad was the asshole who had the illegal slaves in his back yard- he got beat with a metal pipe regularly and had seen some shit in his short life so he wasn’t shocked by the new kid- he simply asked “ why are you doing that? “ Yeah why didn’t we ask why?!

We just watched silently as he performed his pervert ballet amongst smashed roaches and the glow of VCR porn-

“ Cause I’m crazy” the kid said- Randy and I looked at each other and thought - yeah he was crazy, that made total sense- but that wasn’t enough for Paco- “ You’re not crazy “ he said “ Yes I am” the kid quickly answered-

My eyes were bouncing back and forth like ping pong balls- at Paco- at the new kid- as they bantered back and forth about what and who was really crazy- “ Oh yeah if you’re really crazy than take a shit right now on this corner “ Paco said with his mic drop moment- “yeh take a shit right here lets see who is crazy!” I thought-

The new kid giggled “ ok ha ha ha-hahaha “ as he squat down right there on the corner and pulled his sweats all the way off- Randy and I were shocked- Paco was unimpressed-

I kept looking around waiting for an adult or something to tell us to stop but there was no one around with Randy’s mom doin who knows what in the bedroom next to the sidewalk and our moms at work-

After giggling and squatting for awhile the new kid stood up and sure enough there was a little poop on the ground “

see I'm crazy " he said with that now scary laugh- Paco stood with arms crossed not convinced at this psycho fucks craziness- " if you're crazy you'll pick up that shit and rub it on the windshield of that truck " Paco said as he pointed to the innocent truck parked on the corner-

As soon as he said it the giggly new kid picked the piece of shit up with his bare hands and started smearing it all over the windshield of the truck "JIMMMMY!" a man screamed out from the new kids house- the new kid stopped rubbing the shit on the truck put his dick away and ran off home giggling. Randy and I stood there in shock as Paco still had his arms crossed, still not impressed-

Years later I ran into Jimmy- who was now a member of the Marine corp serving in Iraq- Randy also joined the Marines strangely enough- Paco went to prison as a child and got out as a young man- I haven't heard from him in years but I hope he's still free- he was younger than me but he was my mentor of crazy and my best friend for awhile when we were kids-

PACO: THE FINAL BOSS OF CRAZY

Why was Paco not impressed with Jimmy's crazy actions? Well let me give you a sampling of his normal extracurricular activities- for one we lived right near a long busy one way street that cars would speed through all hours of the day- Pacos' dad had a landscaping business- A fun activity for eight year old Paco was to run in his backyard- get a pair of his dad's kneepad's like the ones roofers wear-

As we watched- he'd put them on and run over towards the one way street- toward the cars waiting at the spotlight to speed down the one way to the next stop light- this crazy little fuck would sneak behind a car and kneel while grabbing onto the back bumper of the car- the light would turn green- he laughed as the car dragged him on his knees at 50 mph-

Sparks flying up through his mop of curly black hair- the car would stop at the next light- he would let go and run back to us with a smile on his face running awkwardly with the over sized knee pads- so yeh he knows crazy-

We were all nuts but he was definitely the best at it. Though when I started making pipe bombs from brass door knobs and crushing snails on my forehead I gave him a brief run for his money.

When he found his dad's shotgun shells- from the shotgun his dad fired into the air at new years and the fourth of July and threatened to shoot people with "who fucked with him"- Paco would haul out the large vice into his front yard in our residential neighborhood next to an elementary school- lock the shotgun shells into the vise and hit them with a hammer until they exploded-

Paco liked to fight- because of it he spent a lot of time in jail- Though the thing that got him locked up the first time was a noble cause- and a tough thing to handle for a 13 year old-

Paco's uncle had been molesting his daughter- molesting Paco's female cousin- She had a brother who was a crazy kid too- when the brother found out about his dad molesting his sister he and Paco formulated a plan to kill the uncle- they had a BB gun and molotov cocktails I believe-

Before they could kill the twisted old fuck they were caught by the cops- the male cousin eventually got a new name and a foster family as his dad went to prison for molesting his own daughter- Paco went to juvenile hall as he had a prior record for fighting in school-

He first went to juvenile camp- then to "the ranch" a detention center for boys and young men- I think he got in fights there which gave him more time- so he went into the system at about age 13 I believe and bounced around different institutions till he was around 25- thats the last time I saw him-

PCP KITCHEN UTENSILS

One night there was a pickup truck parked at the corner of our block on the same corner the flaming cockroach holocausts took place on- we had a good supply of firecrackers given to us by Paco's brother who was a routine gas huffer-

Once we heard a man yelling, moaning and loud banging sounds in Paco's backyard we ran back there and found him running around with a gas can stuck to his face knocking into stuff- he had forgotten to exhale to release the suction of the gas can while huffing and panicked- and that's your big brother- he was also illiterate- this big brother-

Your big brother who went to his probation officer one day and came back a few days later wearing an eyepatch- not many people in the neighborhood really know what happened to his eye but being an insider in their family I learned the truth-

He went to his monthly appointment to see his probation officer or P.O. as its known- while sitting in the waiting room he realizes he has some pcp in his pocket- pcp or angel dust- the stuff of neighborhood legends of the man who punched through a car or tore off his own skin- or this story I'm about to tell you-

So mind you Paco's brother was not a smart man- his hobbies included huffing gas and another game they would try to get me to play with them- lets all put boxing gloves on and turn the lights off in a small dark room and punch each other- I'd agree to play then duck to the floor and let them all knock each other out and break each others noses and jaw's-

So this guy realizes- I'm in a building with police officers and I'm in a drug probation program and I have pcp in

my pocket- hmm what should I do? Well if I take it then they won't find it on me! GULP! Problem solved-

So while sitting in the waiting room he has a pcp freakout- yelling- screaming- I am invincible- I am Jesus- the whole pcp experience- the cops in the building chase him around the office so he picks up a fork he finds on someones desk and gouges his own eye out- I guess the police felt sorry for him and they let him go home a few days later-

Another time this same big brother ran through my families back yard being chased by two police officers with their guns out when I was back there playing-

So that brother who through all that I have to say was nice to me- I think a lot of his problems stemmed from his illiteracy- he couldn't read a word- I helped teach Paco to read myself when he was little-

I was always reading books and had no interest in the "Cholo" stuff most kids were doing- thats Mexican gang stuff- so since I always read books I was looked at like the smart kid- so the smart kid on the block had to help his little friend read so he didn't end up like his brother-

TRUCK TRUCK BANG BANG

Paco's brother had given us some firecrackers- what should be do? We had been sticking the firecrackers in apples we got off of the tree next to the neighborhood church- lighting them and throwing them at anyone we could find- that was fun for two bad children but it was Friday- we wanted to do something bad, new, fun, and exciting-

We ran over to the truck parked at the corner of the block and laid down in the bed- we were pretty small kids at the time so if you looked at the truck when we were laying in the bed you couldn't see us- we didn't know what we wanted to do- we were just laying in the bed of this truck as we stared up at the hazy sky-

A few stars trying to punch through the smog- why were we so bad? Is it because we had no supervision? No positive male role models? Or were we just bad? I wanted badly to join the boy scouts like my older half-brother I looked up to but there were no boy scout troops in my neighborhood- so I read his old boy scout books he gave me- I used what I learned to make explosives and devise ways to kill things-

So there we were laying in the bed of that truck when we heard the rumble of a car- a car we couldn't see had pulled up next to us to stop at the light- I looked over at Paco who had that glimmer in his eye- that look in his eye that appeared before some crazy shit happened- he lifted a pack of firecrackers above us- lit it and threw it toward the car next to us- pop pop pop pop pop- the firecrackers exploded as the cars tires squealed, tearing down the street- we laughed so hard we lost our breaths-

How could something so simple be so awesome I wondered- for an evil kid it was the best- the mischief- the not being caught- we did it a few more times- it was a great time

scaring the shit out of these people we didn't know- again, we were bad kids- unsupervised kids with nothing to do- no one to tell us what to do- no one to tell us what not to do- no where to play at night- so this is what we did- and outside of the drivers no one seemed to care-

After doing it for about half an hour- we were almost out of firecrackers- a new car pulled up purring next to us- it sounded like a sports car- we lit and threw- pop pop pop pop- the car squealed off- we laughed and a few minutes later another car pulled up next to us- I hesitated as it had the same purr as the last car- but we were reckless crazy kids so we lit and threw- pop pop pop pop- a call door open and slammed shut " where are you?! You god damn son of a bitches!" an irate man yelled out toward all corners-

With hands pressed over out mouths feeling a mixture of terror and trying really hard not to laugh- it was hard to breathe- don't laugh- don't make a sound- might die- we could hear the man's heavy hurried footsteps walking around us-

It was terrifying as he stalked around us- all he had to do was look over into the bed of the truck and we were dead- a deserted street corner- this enraged man- he cursed and stomped and eventually he left- as soon as we heard his car drive away we let loose our laughs- the elation- the terror- it was wonderful being a bastard son of a bitch in the inner city that night- we laid there for awhile ignoring the cars that stopped next to us because we had gotten our fill of fun- we made sure no one was looking then we crawled out of the truck bed and went home-

We went home to overheated houses with not enough room and watched pro wrestling on TV- if I could only learn how to do a real figure-four things might just turn out alright-

GHETTO BAZOOKA TUBES

Being bastard kids with no supervision got us into all sorts of trouble- a lot of it involved throwing things at cars or drunk people- we were terrors on our street that we policed and patrolled with wrist rockets, bb guns, mud balls, fruit with firecrackers in them, and our most impressive weapon of all- a bundle of bottle rockets with a pvc pipe to fire them out of-

We were all pretty poor so we didn't have the newest toys that shined on TV commercials aimed at us- we didn't own Nintendo Entertainment Systems but we did have our very own fucking rocket launcher that we fired at real people every night-

We were pro's- I held the launcher tube and Paco lit the rockets- we could work really fast- ready in seconds- and we had to be- as our favorite target stumbled by every night- the big boss man is what we called him- all the kids on our street knew him because he would come by every night- drunk out of his mind- mumbling- singing- cussing- pissing on a fence-

There was a bar up the street that big boss man frequented- it was one of our favorite things to do those summer nights-

A big boss man sighting would take place around 10pm every night " big boss man!" would echo down the street- our friends knew that Paco and I would man the artillery and take care of big boss man and they loved to see it- these were our fireworks- we'd grab the pipe and the matches or lighter-

Being little pyromaniacs we always had fire handy- we'd watch big boss man approach as we did in the bushes- the sounds of his dress shoes scuffed as he stumbled down the street singing or cursing- He looked like a business man- an asian

business man- a salary man- and we were about to pay him his salary- Five bottle rockets right up the-

As soon as he passed we'd kick the gate open- stand in the middle of the sidewalk and scream " big boss man! " at first he didn't respond- but after about the tenth time he knew the drill- this was the tenth time- big boss man turned around and looked at us- terror in his eyes as he tried to commandeer his intoxicated faculties to move down the street-faster-

Must escape crazy fucking kids?!- kneeling with the pvc pipe aiming at his butt "fire" I yelled out as Paco lit the fuse- the smell of gunpowder and smashed plums on the sidewalk as I inhaled deeply ready to launch a volley at our eternal foe big boss man- whoosh! -a bottle rocket rushed out of the tube BANG exploding a few feet to the left of his business slacks as he hobbled down the street-

I could see the glimmer of his glasses as he looked back trying to gauge when the next rocket would come- "reload" I yelled- "fire" another rocket fired at big boss man with report- another- another- as we laughed and cheered chasing this drunk man off of our street- it was some kind of strange victory for these young boys none of them with good fathers- most of them with none-

Did we see this big boss man as our absent father? Chasing him off- telling him " we don't want you any way! get out " Is that how we dealt with our feelings of abandonment? By hating this strange man and chasing him away from our homes- I don't know now- were we just little shits or was there something deeper behind our rage? We never harassed or harmed any women- we all had moms- most of them good and hard working- they may have hit us with broom handles or thrown knives at us but they were still good-

FART JUICE

You were supposed to be tough, thats what my best friend Bobby and I thought when we were ten years old. Being tough was the best thing ever, the best thing any boy could be was a tough boy. So how do you measure this boy toughness? Now at the time I didn't figure this out but as an adult the motivation for our tough criteria is now as clear as fart juice.

What is fart juice? You say?

One of the main criteria for being tough was the ability to fart. Fart as big and loud and as often as possible. The bigger the fart the tougher the boy. Fart bigger, longer and louder and you were the toughest boy around and every boy wanted to be the toughest boy around.

When the neighborhood kids got into the regular " My dad can beat up your dad " argument I just sat back and watched them. I never said a thing. I didn't need a dad to think I was tough because I had fart juice son.

So my best friend and I were always on the lookout for the secret formula to the biggest, toughest farts we could forcibly expel from our bad little boy buttocks.

Since we were both very gifted in the art of breaking wind we must have decided that since we were so good at it, it should be one of the main criteria for toughness. Automagically we would be the toughest boys around. How convenient for us.

Breaking things with ones head was another major test of toughness. So we would head butt everything and everyone we could find as often as possible. The things we head butted included crushing live snails on our foreheads and denting soup

cans which I'm sure lead to some brain damage making me the amazing human bean I am today.

Maybe grape soda was the formula for the best farts? Maybe it was those rice candies with the melty wrappers they sold at the Japanese market down the street where we would throw down all the change we had to buy packs of baseball cards dusted with powdered sugar from the stick of gum inside, fuck the gum! We just wanted the rookie cards, fuck everything else give us tough boys the rookies so we can fart on em and show em what tough life was really like.

Anyway, we were young researchers doing important work. We needed to find the ultimate fart formula. Mankind needed us, they just didn't know it yet.

That year in the tenth age of tough boys we discovered the ultimate formula- we discovered the fart juice.

What I'm about to tell you might change your life forever. If you've longed to be tough, to fart louder and harder than your peers, well then I have the explosive piece of secret information that you've been waiting for your entire life.

We discovered the mythical fart juice by chance, through accident- like many great discoveries have been. Great discoveries like gravity, electricity, and spam.

So now the part you've all been waiting for. What is fart juice made out of? Where can I buy it?

Much like the other great discovery, gravity- fart juice's discovery had to do with trees and fruit.

The house I grew up in as a kid had a plum tree in the back yard. We'd hang out in that yard there eating different

things to see if they produced bigger and better farts. Chew this plant, take a bite of that fruit.

Bobby picked a green plum off of the tree and a few seconds after chewing and swallowing the small bitter fruit BOOM a loud fart shot out of his tough boy buttocks. “Mike!” he said “I think I’ve discovered it!” I ran over towards him “try this” he said as he handed me a small green plum “ I think these things make you fart “ he added, astonished.

I chewed it up a little and swallowed it and BOOM a monstrous fart fired off into space from my tough buy butt. “I think we’ve discovered it” Bobby said breathing quick shallow breaths. We tore through the branches eating plum after plum farting all the way through. A cycle of cheering, laughing, farting, farting, always with the farting.

“ We should call this fart juice “ Bobby said with a bright smile on his face. “ We’re going to be rich “ I added as I had assumed it was everyones number goal in life to fart as much as possible at all times. I mean, everyone wanted to be tough didn’t they? I mean EVERYONE just wanted to fart all the time didn’t they? YES, so we would be rich from this fart juice.

“ We should bottle it and sell it “ I said as we both turned and looked up at the tree with shiny sparkles in our boy eyes. Look at all that fart juice growing up there!

We did milk enough plums to make one jar of fart juice. It was an old pickle jar with a piece of white paper taped on to it with the words “FART JUICE” written on it in little boy writing with a pencil.

It took longer than 5 minutes to create the fart juice jar so we lost inspiration in our fart juice get rich quick plan, but we did

finish the rest of the jar. Many loud, hard farts were had. We came, we saw, we farted.

Once we had conquered the top of Maslow's hierarchy of tough needs with the fart juice we moved on to other areas to make new world changing discoveries. We had farted enough to know that we were probably, NO, we knew were the best in the world at farting and it was a shame that it was not an olympic sport as we would have both won medals for sure.

I'll never have any children but Bobby has two boys. I know that one day when they are ready he will pass down the secret of the fart juice to them. Family, its all about family.

ROACH COACH MUD FACIALS

We bad kids did have several run ins with the police with our little adventures- the first of which took place one day as Paco and I were not in school at the time- me refusing to go- he, suspended for fighting- it just had rained the day before and we had some wonderful mud in my backyard-

We were bored as we sculpted several mud balls- or more like mud shells- I had watched a Donald Duck cartoon earlier in the day wherein his nephews made artillery shells out of snow and sunk Donald's boat with them so I was making mud artillery shells- so Paco and I were standing there with a long line of hand sculpted artillery shells made of mud-

There was a "roach coach" business down the street where we lived- now they are called "food trucks" they've been rebranded so people see them as something nice- back them they were literally roach coaches- dirty things that sold crappy food and their home base was up out street-

It made our neighborhood stink like trash whenever it got warm so we hated the roach coaches- we were standing there as a roach coach drove by- they all had these ridiculous obnoxious horns they'd blow to attract people where ever they stopped- but they also always blew them when they passed our houses- the stink- the noise-

BAM as a mud artillery shell slammed into the side of a passing roach coach- I liked baseball and fancied myself a pitcher so I liked to throw things- and I had just thrown the first mud ball at a roach coach-

Paco laughed at the mud stuck to the side of the meandering roach coach- there was a woman's face painted on the side of the truck and she now had a mud dot on her forehead-

we laid down some ground rules for mud throwin- we'd only throw them at roach coaches- another one approached BAM BAM we both nailed it- marring up the face of the woman painted on the side of it-

We did this for hours- here comes the roach coaches squeaking shocks- stupid horn blaring- BAM BAM- we had our ground rules so no other cars- roach coaches only- some of the roach coaches didn't have a window or door on the drivers side- it was just open exposing the driver to mud artillery shells fired from the pitching ambitions of unsupervised nine year olds-

One of these open air roach coaches cruised by- Paco threw his mud shell BAM- I threw mine which curved right into the open drivers side- it didn't make a sound- the roach coach slowed to a stop and after a few seconds kept going- "it must have missed" I thought- this was a yellow coach with palm trees painted on the side- our enthusiasm had waned- Paco had to go check in with his mom back home-

He left then hollered at me before going down the street to pick up some clothes at the dry cleaners- I kept throwing mud at roach coaches while he was gone- a few minutes he bursts back into the road " Mike you hit him! You hit him in the face! " he gasped " He was parked outside of the cleaners- that roach coach! he was cleaning the mud off his face!" he said- " we better stop or we're gonna get busted"

Getting busted- the fear of all bastard bad kids- level one- hit by your mom or dad with some foreign object- level two- the cops come and you go to Juvee or juvenile hall- being a little bastard punk- I didn't care- I kept throwing mud at roach coaches as Paco watched trying to get me to stop- creak- a yellow roach coach with palm trees on it approached " don't do that one Mike thats the one you hit" Paco gasped-

I watched it roll down the street- bouncing softly on creaky shocks- blaring its annoying horns, stinking up our neighborhood- “ No don’t do it” Paco screamed and I threw the mud ball- BAM- slamming into the side of the roach coach it stopped and the driver looked right into my eyes- “oh shit he saw us, run! Paco said as he hopped the back fence-

I ran and hid in the bushes as the man walked up to the house to look at the address- I knew I was fucked- I knew there was no escape- later that night after my mom came home from work I waited on the front porch for the police- they did come- they talked to me- they talked to her- luckily I didn’t get arrested or have to go to juvenile hall- maybe the cops didn’t like those fucking roach coaches either- I never threw another thing at another motor vehicle again- that year-

40'S AT 11

A few years later when I was 11- my best friend Bobby and I were bored- he had a 40 of St. Ide's malt liquor just like the ones from the commercials that featured one of our heroes Ice Cube- I wasn't interested in drinking at 11 but Bobby was- I was just interested in Baseball- so we decided to combine both of our interests that night at the nearby elementary school-

We collected a bunch of lemons from a tree near the school and held as many as we could in lap of our T-shirts- he couldn't hold as many as me as he had to hold his 40 too- we stopped on the baseball field- instead of facing the back stop we faced the one way street that had lots of traffic pouring through it at high speeds-

We had heard stories from one of our friends that threw stuff at cars- they said they had hit a pizza delivery car which stopped and chased them- as the driver was chasing them another kid went in the car and stole the pizza's- this sounded great as Bobby had beer but no pizza-

I saw adults having both at the same time- I was hungry at the time so it seemed like a great idea- I also thought it would be good practice for me to practice pitching out there that night - I wound up as the cars approached firing juicy lemons that exploded on drivers side windows- we never killed anyone or caused an accident but we easily could of- we were bad kids-

So Bobby was sitting there drinking his 40 at 11 as I pretended to pitch an invisible perfect game to the windshields and side panels of passing cars- my strike zone was drivers side windows- whoosh- splat- we waiting for a pizza delivery car but one never came- it wasn't long before the police showed up- we ran but they caught us easily as they hauled ass in reverse up a

one way street- we didn't think they'd do that so they got us there-

So there we were caught red handed- two eleven year olds- one with a forty ounce of beer ten years too early to drink legally- we're fucked- the police start talking to us-

We tell them what we did- they seem to be going harder on me and I can't understand why as Bobby was the one drinking the beer- and not even good beer at that- nasty ass orange malt liquor ten years too early- but my best friend Bobby was the best at everything- especially bullshitting- he spun an awesome lie-

I watched in amazement as the police ate it up- " My grandpa died last night and I'm just really sad- I saw this beer in the fridge so I just took it and drank it I didn't know what else to do " he said in a sad soft voice " Its ok son we understand " the policeman said " you can go home " he added as Bobby winked at me and walked on home- that bastard leaving me there with the police-

I don't blame him he was just smarter and scrappier than me- he was smooth- I was anything but smooth with my autistic social skills I honed home alone away from other kids besides my punk friends while I memorized insects in my field guide and built home made bombs out of brass door knobs-

The police didn't like me at all- three of them went hard on me then called my mom to pick me up- they proceeded to tell her that I was on drugs- probably stimulants they said- they knew I wasn't on drugs but they knew in saying that my mom would hound me every other day the following years asking " are you on drugs?! " any time I acted funny- I deserved it being the bastard punk kid I was and that was the last time I ever threw anything at motor vehicles ever.

ANGELS FOR AN HOUR AND A HALF

At age seven I was a good catholic boy- I made my communion after going to Sunday school for 6 months with this teacher who told the same exact story each week- every week he told the story of the prodigal son- every Saturday morning we would be jammed into this little classroom behind the church and this crispy looking man who looked like captain kangaroo going through chemo would say “this week I’m going to tell the story of the prodigal son” and us kids would look over at each other like “ we already heard this before- he did it last week “ but we were all good little catholic boys so we went ahead with things we didn’t like doing- things we didn’t understand because our parents told us to do so-

When I asked adults why I had to do these things their best answer was “ so you can get married in a church” My young mind confused “ I guess thats important? ok “ What a thing to tell an 8 year old? You’ve already decided that they are going to get married and in a church on top of that?

Maybe we just went along with it because we knew it was bullshit- most of us brought walkman’s and stealthy black headphones with us- one week I remember softly pressing play on my walkman play button so the teacher telling the same story as the week before wouldn’t hear my “Too Short” tape playing- life is too short so sit in catechism without listening to freaky tales from Oakland-

I looked over the name of the tape that the kid next to me was listening too “Oaktown 357” - “I’ve got to get that tape I thought” as “Juicy” was a catchy song although my 8 year old mind that hadn’t seen porno movies yet didn’t understand the true meaning of the song.

So we sat there every week ignoring this crazy old dude who said the same thing over and over while we listened to bay area rappers- the next year the church announced to us that that teacher had died as he had an inoperable brain tumor- his brain was obviously broken as he babbled his redundant nonsense to us each week- its odd that no one noticed that he was out of his fucking mind- a broken robot stuck on a loop-

Its really weird how such things slip through the cracks when "god" is involved. There was one quiet kid my age who was in my class at school and in my catechism classes- he didn't say much so we all thought he was a good kid- he was harmless- he just liked baseball cards and never started any trouble with anyone- he wasn't a bully- he didn't talk back to teachers- he barely said a word-

In that 8 year old Sunday school class we were all to make our "Holy Communion" part of which was to go into a dank old wooden booth and confess your sins to some old man on the other side.

We had to do this on a Sunday morning before church- lined up in front of the confessional it was 15-20 of us- whispering amongst ourselves as we wondered what kind of punishments we'd get and how things went- the few kids who went to church outside of their requirements to get married in a church described to us how things would go- I was a part timer - only in it to get married in a church so I never went to church when I didn't have too- I'd rather watch pro wrestling-

So we're standing there in the dim church- the glow of prayer candles behind us as we clasp our filthy little hands and try to act holy- most of us were savages- spitting and wrestling and making fart sounds twenty three hours a day but right now we were holy- wearing tiny little white ties with magic cufflinks placed meticulously by our mothers- in this holy place waiting to

be judged by some weird old man whose face we couldn't see- by a faceless voice that exercised all power over us- in that box there was no conversation- there was confession- you were a sinner-

There was no doubt you were a sinner and this man was here to absolve you of your sins- some of the good kids hadn't really done anything bad and they were worried that they had nothing to confess so they asked us- the bad kids- for advice " just tell them you lied or talked back to your parents" we would say- I couldn't really tell the priest what I had done as I was speeding along the how to make a serial killer speed way-

I tortured animals- I set things on fire- I hurt people badly on purpose- but I wasn't going to say that- I just said " I told some lies and talked back to my parents "

Amongst the kids we knew who was a bad kid and who was a good kid- my best friend and I knew we were bad kids but we weren't the worst kids- you knew who the worst kids were because they had already pulled Rambo knives on you or beat you up-

There was that quiet kid- lets call him Johnny- we all thought he was a good kid- the only thing we knew about him that was out of the ordinary was that he had a younger sister that had died- but we didn't know how she died and we never knew her-

So we waited quietly in our white suits so we could lie and be judged by some weird old fuck we didn't respect- and why should we have? He was too afraid to show his face- silently judging us like he was some holy being- he was just some repressed old man wearing weird clothes- we told our lies and went outside-

KILLA GOD BOYZ

Everyone waited outside to share their sentence- you walked up to every kid you knew and asked “what did you get?” everyone got something like “ three our fathers, four Hail Mary’s “ which were the names of prayers and the number of times they were supposed to say them to be absolved of your sins- pretty handy eh? So as I went from kid to kid asking about their sentences and sharing mine- we laughed and made jokes-

As I was laughing in my light blue suit with white tie I noticed my best friend and fellow serial killer in progress, Bobby- standing silently over near the “good kid” , Johnny- Bobby’s eyes scanning the ground working out a great problem in his mind- not finding an answer- “Whats the matter?” I asked “ Go ask Johnny” he said making eye contact with me- “ask him what?” I answered “ Ask him what he got “ he said-

I looked over at Johnny who was leaning on a light pole in his light blue suit with white tie- he was hunched over like an old man-

Come to think of it he was always hunched over- he never played sports either he just stood off to the side with this posture- this old man posture- “ why, what happened ?” I asked Bobby “ Just ask him “ he said- I was a bit confused as my best friend Bobby had all the answers- he was the cool kid- the best athlete- the funniest- the toughest- the biggest smart ass- and he was taken aback by something-

He was surprised and confused which was odd for an 8 year old alpha male like him-

I heard a story about Bobby that took place later when he was in the 7th grade- so around age twelve- I went to school

maybe once a week or two times each month as I was a truant so I wasn't always there to see what was going on as I was bullied myself- getting my nose broken by a bully after I fought back after class one day so I wasn't very excited about attending middle school- you had Physical education class to look forward to wherein at every opportunity groups of kids tried to pull your shorts down, stick saliva soaked fingers in your ears or just physically hurt you for no reason at all- so yeah I went to school as little as possible-

But I do remember a substitute teacher named Mr. R. - he was a pretty flamboyant gay man- he was flirty with the boys in the class- he teased them and hit on them some times- the boys were twelve and he was in his late twenties-

From the story I heard- the teacher had been flirty with Bobby in class and was making passes at him commenting on how cute he was and so on- things you don't want to say to a twelve year old alpha male boy that was drinking 40's at age eleven and could kick anyones ass up and down without breaking a sweat-

Apparently Bobby asked the teacher to stop calling him cute and the like- he warned the teacher he was going to "beat his ass" but Mr. R. egged him on- who knows- maybe he had a fetish for getting beat up by pre-pubescent boys? There's weirder stuff out there- if he did- that's what he got-

Bobby approached the front of the class and pummeled the grown man Mr. R in front of the whole class until he was lying in fetal position on the floor begging for mercy- after which Bobby told Mr. R. to not tell anyone- he never did- but all the kids knew as he got his ass kicked in front of the class-

OVER 9000 OUR FATHERS

So Bobby, the slayer of substitute teachers was shaken by something- I knew that it had to be something serious-

I looked up at Johnny and walked over near him- standing on the other side of the telephone pole he was leaning on- I looked down at his polished white shoes and hands clasped together tightly- pressing the palms together with too much force and kneading his thumbs over the tops of his hands- “what?” his voice annoyed old man voice cracked- his grumpy tone like a toad croaking upon the first rain fall-

He looked up at me with his eyes under his brow without moving his head- when he did this combined with his old man posture he did not seem like one of us- he seemed older- like an old man trapped in a kids body-

I tapped my toes against the pavement looking over at Bobby who looked back at me as I scuffed the tips of my shoes- “ so what did you get?” I said to Johnny making eye contact with him again- he looked away then down- “why?” he asked- I pressed on “ I don’t know, I was just asking everybody what they got “ I answered- he looked away further down the street trying to escape this interaction with his devilish little peer who looked like an innocent angel- an angel who forgot to tell the priest that he had hidden under a chair only to emerge in a dark room and stick a two inch hat pin all the way into his grandma’s butt cheek as she screamed out loudly- howling in pain as he returned to his hiding place under the chair- his grandma half senile never knew who assaulted her that day or why-

Johnny didn’t know I was a bad kid but I knew he was a good kid- so I waited for his standard reply of “ four Hail Mary’s and five our fathers”

He opened his mouth and a sound came out- it slipped out of a creak in tightly sealed doors that was his personality- never saying much- never expressing much- always seeming distracted- always seeming like he was somewhere else- like he was a fifty year old stock trader locked up with a bunch of kids that knew nothing and cared not about the market-

“ Two hundred Our Fathers and four hundred Hail Mary’s “ is the sound that came out of his mouth- it didn’t register at first- I just stood there silently as he continued “ thats what I got- is there anything else you want to know “ he said in a bitchy tone looking away down the street-

I stepped back and over next to my best friend Bobby- “ what do you think he did?” I whispered- “ I don’t know- something really bad “ he answered- we waited out there till our parents had walked down the street to pick us up- most of all of us were picked up by our mom’s as most of us didn’t have fathers present-

The last thing I remember about that day is that we had never seen Johnny’s mom- his dad picked him up- a shifty little man that walked with a limp- a truckers hat low over his face- he seemed uneven- shaky- shifty even- Johnny followed him as they disappeared down the street-

We looked at Johnny differently that day because we knew he had done something really bad but we didn’t know what it was- then I thought to myself “ what if I told the priest what I really did- what would I have gotten? “ maybe Johnny was like me except that he told the truth to the priest? I didn’t know what to think-

I knew I was a liar but I didn’t have any problem doing so- I didn’t feel guilty lying- I didn’t even feel guilty doing the

horrible things I had done because of things that had happened to me when I was 2 or 3-

I was a damaged child- maybe Johnny was damaged too- maybe he just told the truth? Maybe all of us kids lied to the priest? Thats something I'll never know- I just know that Johnny was different in some way-

LIE SCHOOL DIPLOMA

Fast forward ten or so years- I'm riding the public bus home from community college- sitting in the back with my headphones cranked full blast like they often were- once a bus driver stopped the bus- walked to the back and demanded I turn them down-

I did- and when that very overweight bus driver got off when there was a transfer of drivers I made sure to wave out the window and say " See ya round tubby" as I slammed the window- that was the day I was suspended in community college- did you know that was possible?

To be "suspended" in college? I mean it was community college which is really just like high school 2.0 for those of us that couldn't afford to go to a four year right away or we wanted to save money doing our basic requirements at one quarter the price- thats why I was there- well that and that I didn't really attend school grades 4 through 10-

I went back to high school in grade 11 to copulate and to play baseball- which I did- but I was far from having the credits to graduate and I didn't want to waste my time trying to get a diploma or a GED so I went to community college checking a box that I had a diploma on the application- they never asked for it-

I worried about them asking for it up until I received my Bachelors degree from San Jose State University in the mail- but no one ever asked for it-

Speaking of San Jose State University- while I was in that little community college surrounded by freeways- the constant hum of traffic distracting you when you were trying to

write an essay in class- I met a very special girl with some very down to earth expectations that she had for the world in regard to her choice of colleges to transfer too-

IVY LEAGUE CANS, CAN?

So I was in this run down community college so I could take the classes I needed to transfer to San Jose State University- your average college - not known for anything in particular- when I asked the faculty member in charge of advising students who were transfer students if my gpa was good enough to get into San Jose State his answer was " do you have a pulse? " he asked " yes" I answered " then you will get into San Jose State its as simple as that " he said- so it was a very easy school to get into to-

It wasn't some prestigious school like Stanford University to the north- *not even close-*

So I was about nineteen at the time in community college when I met this girl who was the same age- I don't know how or why I met her- but we were talking in the schools lounge wherein they had a bunch of couches and a big screen TV- it was the normal community college chit chat- were are you transferring to? What classes are you taking?

Now I don't remember how or why I met her I just remember this conversation- now I should say this its important to explaining this particular story- she was a physically attractive girl with giant tits- like so big no matter what she wore it was obvious she had huge tits and by her clothing choices she made it even more obvious-

Maybe thats why I don't remember how or why I met her?

Maybe I was hypnotized by the sine wave pattern of her undulating oversized breasts as I was weak to the power of the titties at age 19- who was I to say no to a wall of tits back then?

She had a brand new sports car that her dad had bought her- she had new clothes- a shiny new watch- she was on top of the world there at San Jose City Community college- from the way she spoke and by what she said she didn't seem very smart-

So we're talking about nothing when I asked the standard community college question of " So where are you going to transfer to? " when she dropped this bomb on me-

She turned her head and smiled with massive boobs shaking with every move " well I'm going to transfer to San Jose state….or Harvard " she said *matter of factly*-

I nodded my head with the movement of her boobs until I caught it " wait, did she just say Harvard?! " I thought- I looked into her eyes- she was %100 serious " Harvard? " I said with a cough trying not to laugh " yeah I heard its a pretty good school " she said- again matter of factly-

I looked around to make sure we weren't on one of those hidden camera TV show's " yeah I heard that too " I said, confused-

I knew her tits were an island oasis where heterosexual male fantasies were born and lived premature ejaculating lives but could those tits take her all the way to Harvard?

Was there even a waterway she could use them to float on all the way there? I went over maps with rivers on them in my mind- it was impossible! Then how?!

I mean most any straight man would probably do whatever she wanted if she got to speak to them one on one and used her boob hypnotism on them- but I mean she was liable to run into a gay man or a straight woman- then what?

Where would her tit powers end? I mean what she going to drop on me next “ I’m going to be a secretary or the president of the United States “ I mean who am I to say? She could have been a genius that just acted dumb too? Maybe she did go to Harvard and is the president of the United States now? She could be as I haven’t been paying attention-

Maybe she should of have been the president of the United States if she already isn’t?

Pacifying the nation of angry men with boob hypnotism-

Ending world wars with her innocent ignorant charm and bouncy ways- feeding the hungry- maybe they should have let her into Harvard? I wonder if she even applied?

What did her application look like? I don’t remember how the conversation ended-

I think I talked to her a few more times after that but I don’t remember any of it- she would just drone on and on about boring nonsense expecting me to be interested because she was “hot” but I wasn’t- I was a community college rebel maaaaaaan! No! I won’t try to bang your hot chicks maaaaaaan! I’m a community college rebel maaaaaaan!

COMMUNITY COLLEGE REBEL STANCE

I got suspended one day in that community college after a science teacher called a friend and I over at the end of class- she was a thin nervous looking woman with bad skin and crispy hair- her voice weak and shaky- I never said so to her of course- I was mostly only a jerk in my head- I never said anything to her before then- I was just another student in the class- or so I thought- My friend and I weren't disruptive in class- we were never asked to be quiet- we were never asked anything by the teacher- it was just another normal class as far as I thought- but this teacher didn't think so- but I didn't know that yet-

She called my friend and I over as class was ending " Michael, Steve- I need to talk to you after class" Steve and I looked at each other- me with a shaved head and a tight maroon polyester shirt and cutoff tan dockers of all things-

Steve with long lochs of black hair and doc martens- we shrugged our shoulders and walked towards the front of the class- " The Dean of the school will be here in five minutes to talk to you two about your misconduct " she said with an intense shaky voice- " what why?" I said " what did we do?" Steve asked- she put her hand out in front of her as if to point at us but she was too passive aggressive to do so " You know what you did" she said " No we don't" I said interrupting her- She waved to someone outside the classroom " he's here now lets go outside " she said as we all moved out of the classroom-

Steve and I looked at each other- eyes rolling like only 19 year olds with polyester shirts that are too small can roll. A tall thin man in a suit waited for us- hands crossed over one another " are you Michael?" he asked " yes" I answered " are you Steven?" he asked " yes I am" said Steve-

So there we were- the Dean of the community college standing in front of us with the nervous teacher behind him- " your teacher has informed me about your behavior and I find it quite unacceptable?" he said as she nodded her head- " behavior? what behavior?" I asked- she perked up " talking in class- I hear you talking about me in class- its disruptive to the class and rude " she said with a jittery tone-

The Dean looked at me as I opened my mouth with "this is bullshit" written all over my face " Talking about you in class?! We've never talked about you ever- what are you even talking about?" I asked- " You are always talking about me in class and I've asked you to quiet down several times " She said- " She has never asked us to be quiet ever and we've never talked about her ever " Steve said " The is crazy " he added- the word crazy seemed to agitate the teacher as she rocked back and forth on her feet -

I made eye contact with the Dean " This woman obviously has some issues because she's straight up lying- none of this is true " I said as Steve nodded his head in agreement- as another man in a suit walked over and joined us- " is this all being handled now?" the man said " yes it is" said the Dean as he then informed us that this man was the president of the school. Steve and I looked at each other as this must be a dream- a weird dream that made no sense- but no- it was just a community college in San Jose California that day.

" I think a fitting punishment is too suspend them both for one day " said the Dean- the teacher nodded her head as the president added his two cents " yes I can see that these two are clearly a problem- this one especially" he said as he pointed to me- did he somehow know about the pin I stuck in my grandma's buttocks? Impossible- I stared at him fire in my eyes- trying to burn a hole into the back of his head with telekinetic

powers I didn't have- " he has the body language of a rebellious teenager " he said " Body language? " I asked in a sarcastic tone " yes body language " he repeated " I don't know what that is" I said as he began to explain it " Well you see body language is how you hold…" he was cut off by the Dean " can't you see what he's doing- he understands what you mean" they both looking over at me the 1950's rebel enemy who talks in class about teachers apparently- " no, no, your right I was combing my non existent hair with my switchblade comb in class- come to think of it " I said in a slow lazy tone- " thats not funny " said the Dean as Steve's face started to turn red trying to contain his laughter-

" So you both are not to come to school this coming Monday- you are suspended for one day " said the Dean- the president and the teacher nodding their heads- " ok " I said " is there anything else " I asked hoping one of them would throw a punch at teenage rebel me so I could stab them with my switch blade comb then take off in my hot rod- " no thats it" said the Dean as the three walked away-

Steve and I stood there for a moment- "suspended… in college for talking in class? does that even happen?" I said dumbfounded- "I guess it does now" Steve said as we laughed and concluded that the teacher must be on meth or some other drug that causes paranoid delusions- we said our goodbyes and I hopped on the bus to go home-

Since I had just been repressed by the man- since I just had my teenage rebel wings clipped by authority I had to do something to feel like I was still out of control so I blasted speed metal extra loud on my walkman when the bus driver stopped the bus and asked me to turn it down that day- after that happened I was wondering why these people had such a problem with shaved heads, polyester shirts that were too small and speed metal?

JOHNNY RIDES THE BUS OF EVIL

After I insulted the bus driver and snickered to myself like a jerk I saw a familiar face get on the bus- I was sitting in the back like all teenage rebels do-

I recognized the face on this man- he had long floppy hair and a black hat I didn't read yet- he got on the bus at the stop next to the local strip club- the Pink Poodle-

A friend told me he was waiting at that bus stop once and happened to turn around and saw a line drawn in chalk on the sidewalk behind the bus stop- a line of arrows leading away from the bus bench and towards the back of the strip club- it was dark and he was alone- but he followed the arrow- eventually over a small fence and on top of a one story building and up to a window- within which when he looked in he saw a man banging a stripper from behind-

That was just that other guys story- A story that was told when on the bus as it passed this place- Something to do to take your mind of the exhaust fumes and pounding oppressive heat bouncing off of the tagged on sidewalk that was beaming into your face.

The face of this man on the bus was the same as it was when I last saw it ten years before- clean shaven-boyish- yet complacent with a hint of misery- it was Johnny's face-

I hadn't seen him for ten years- we were about the same age- we grew up in the same neighborhood so I thought I should say hi- I mean how much weirder could the day get after being suspended from college and having to limit the volume of my speed metal in that dingy transit bus-

We had all those commonalities but once I opened my mouth it was obvious that we were worlds apart- “ hey Johnny” I said “ remember me its Mike from school?” He looked up “ hey Mike” he said in a faded tired tone reserved for retirees’- “ what are you doin? goin to school? he asked- “ yeh I’m going to city college- you?” I asked- “ No- just working” he said “ oh yeh- where at?” I asked “ at the pink poodle” he said- “ I work in the bookstore” he added-

I passed that strip club everyday- I would stare into the doorway hoping to see someone I knew so my inner catholic could go “ Ohhhh you’re looking at boobs for money!” but I never saw anyone I knew or much of anyone at all- I knew someone was in there but I never saw them go in- there must have been a back entrance where bikers are banging strippers from behind and where Johnny is right at home-

When I looked over at this fine establishment it read “Bookstore and arcade”- bookstore I got - but arcade?

What pornographic video games were these that I had never heard of? I was fascinated and wanted to know more as I was really into video games and of course, boobs-

I had to know what games these were-

Who made them? Konami? Capcom?

Was there a nude version of Street Fighter 2 I didn’t know about? Was there a Super Mario Bros wherein the Princess gave Mario a hand job when he saved her?

I had to ask Johnny about these games “ so you work in the arcade? “ I asked “yeah” he answered- I was finally going to get my answer-

I didn't have the balls to go in there and find out myself so I was given this opportunity to find out without having to go into an adult establishment " So like, what video games do they have in there" I asked-

Waiting intently for his magical answer to my burning question- " oh they aren't games- you just put a quarter in and it plays a porno" he said-

My juvenile fantasy was instantly deflated- there were no hidden porno video games in that place that featured Pacman with a boner-

I clasped my hands together distraught- " so what do you do there?" I asked- " ah just sell the porno's- restock stuff"

Some times porn stars come in- thats pretty cool " he said " Oh yeah?" I asked even thought I was not up on the latest porn stars news- " yeah we had Ron Jeremy come in last week- that was pretty awesome- he's banged so many hot chicks" he said-

I hadn't banged many "hot chicks" but I knew I was supposed to through the advertising that was aimed at my demographic at the time-

I tried to change the subject so I looked up at this hat which was a Wayne's World hat- Wayne's World was an SNL skit that was turned into a film-

" So you like Wayne's World?" I asked- " it doesn't say Wayne's World" he quickly answered-

I looked up at it again- it had the same design and font as the imagery for the film Wayne's World but it said "Shane's World"- " what's Shane's world" I asked " A porno" he

answered as the drone of the bus and the wind seeping in the window filled up the awkward silence-

I had nothing more to say to this porno man- we lived in two different worlds- his filled with Ron Jeremy, dildo's, Shane's world and bangin bikers "Well it was good seeing you Johnny" I said- he mumbled a something then looked off out the faded cracked window-

Rocking back and forth as the bus rolled forth I watched him- I watched him closely fidget with his bag- move his long hair behind his ears with a look of slight discomfort and confusion on his face when it hit me- three hundred our fathers and four hundred Hail Mary's!

What the hell did Johnny do back then? This miserable porn obsessed man that took my imaginary pac man with a boner away? What did he do? Only that creepy old man whose face we couldn't see in that dingy wooden box knows- he and whoever Johnny committed his crimes or heinous acts against knows- I never saw Johnny again but I'll always wonder-

California, the state that I live in- has a Megan's law website- its a site where you can search for sex offenders by name- I often type Johnny's name in in there but nothing has ever come up- six other people I grew up with do though- Just a handful of rapists and pedophiles you know-

I stare at their mugshots and wonder where they went wrong- or maybe they were always wrong?

Maybe they were always bad? Maybe they all lied to the priest like I did?

They seemed normal back when we were kids- and in normal I mean not sick fucks- two kids from my school

murdered their families as adults- the whole kill the kids to get back at the ex-wife or kill the ex-wife in front of the kids thing-

I played baseball in my two years of high school with one of them- he was an asshole kid- always trying to make fun of everyone around him- the other one was a brother of a friend- quiet guy- seemed nice- he killed his ex-wife in front of his kids and her new boyfriend- the murderers are both alive in prison some where-

DEAD MAN STROKING

At this time in community college I was really into weight training so I was an over-muscled meathead in clothes that were too small and a big chin beard thing- strangers often stopped me at school “ are you Russian?” I was asked a few times “ No. I’m not “ I’d answer as they stood awkwardly “ Oh, I thought you were Russian “ they’d answered then slink off-

I don’t know what that was about- I didn’t look that much like Zangief from StreetFighter 2- the Murican’s idea of a Russian-

My lab partner in Human Anatomy was this big stoner dude- he wrestled in High School so he looked pretty dangerous but he was really laid back-

We liked the class so we worked hard and respected the teacher- the dude has two PhD’s and a beetle named after him that he discovered- legit.

Since we respected this teacher when he introduced the class to the human cadavers we’d be working with that semester we took him seriously when he said “ I don’t know what your religious beliefs are but please respect these cadavers like you would a human being “

Ok, I thought- I can do that- I won’t do anything sick and twisted-

That was until I met a girl who had that very same class the semester before- she showed me some photos she had of that very same teacher clowning around with the cadavers- him smiling with a coke can in the cadavers hand- a trash can on the cadavers head- respect? I thought- ok, I can respect them too-

When we worked on the cadavers- teams of two students did their work in that poorly ventilated lab that stunk of carcinogenic formaldehyde- there were four cadavers- so there were eight students in there at a time- it was fairly close quarters- we all had lab coats on, goggles and gloves-

I took it upon myself to entertain my lab partner who was always high- when other students were looking I'd pretend to do serious work as I removed the cadavers intestines- we were both good students so it didn't seem strange to see us taking this work seriously-

But we weren't there to be serious- at least I wasn't- maybe my partner was- he was high which made him a good audience for my sick slapstick comedy show involving cadavers and their severed limbs and their yellow dissected organs.

As soon as the other students looked away from us I'd start punching the cadaver man in the liver- the cadaver was a big burly guy with a bunch of tattoo's-

I had nothing against him or his corpse- but to me it was just a slab of meat- it was no different than the dead frogs everyone had dissected in High School- though actually I felt more for the frog than I did this human corpse- but that will be in another book-

I'd punch the dead wooden liver hard and fast as my lab partner sprayed chunks of repressed laughter out of his face-

Other students would turn around and look at us and I'd instantly go back to being serious- moving slowly and methodically pointing things out to my partner- his laughter remained so I guess it made him look like a weirdo or a jerk- as it appeared that he was laughing for no reason at this big yellow corpses shoulder muscles.

As soon as the other students looked away again I went back to punching his liver and making my lab partner laugh- back and forth this went— on and on- it almost made this experience of being in this small- poorly ventilated room that reeked of carcinogenic chemicals with several sallow corpses in various stages of disarray- a little more bearable-

I eventually got an A+ in the class- so I did work hard in the class- we just had a little fun with the dead bodies-

Our project was to isolate the muscles in the cadavers shoulder and label them- we finished our cadaver work a few weeks early so we would just use the lab time to fuck around with this dead guy covered with tattoo's-

Some times my partner and I would stay late for some extracurricular work- another group was working on the penis- which they cut off- it was sitting down between his legs-

My high partner and I- I probably had brain damage from the smell of the formaldehyde and was feeling some sort of high as well-

We thought it would be funny to take his penis- put it in his right hand and arrange his body and arm to make it look like he was jerking off- and we happened to have a digital camera we used to document our serious work on the cadaver-

I took some photos of the dead man jerking off- we left an empty coke can and a bag of sunflower seeds under his intestines and closed him up- returning his severed penis to its original place of resting in pee-pee-pieces.

After school I stopped by my friends house that I went to the gym with- I had my backpack with the camera and my friend had a copy of Photoshop and a printer-

I didn't have either so I fired up his PC and imported the photos- my gym partner was a sick fuck too like me- his father was a convicted sex offender- he had the same name as his father so when he got pulled over by the cops they pulled their guns out and treated him like an escaped sex offender until they figured out that he was the sex offenders son and not the man himself- he was probably thinking- The only thing my dad gave me- my dad who abandoned me - the only thing he gave me was his name and it comes in really handy with the police- thanks dad.

I shined up the best photo I had of the masturbating cadaver- I added the following text to the top of the image " Dead man stroking " and this text to the bottom " It's never too late" we printed out ten copies on his new printer-

We were going to stop and eat at a burrito place downtown before we worked out so we thought it would be a great idea to put the printouts on the windshields of parked cars like flyers for a necrophilia party- so we placed the flyers on some cars then we ate burritos and worked out in Golds Gym-

GRANDMAS GUNS MAKE ME FEEL SMALL

I spent a ton of time at Golds Gym between the ages of 16 and 21- it was still a serious gym back then- it wasn't a social club- that happened later-

Like what the fuck bro? What are you doing looking at women and talking to women?

You're only supposed to look at other men muscles- you are only supposed to look at yourself- there was no room for women in this weird narcissistic lifestyle that consisted of protein shakes "Spot me bro" and spending time together in the posing room admiring each others muscles-

Once the gym stopped being a mens club for grunting and critiquing other mens naked muscled bodies I stopped going- I mean- I was there to lift with my bro's and hate myself for not looking like the posters on the wall-

I wasn't there for anything else but to try to build my own wall of giant muscles to protect me from the things I feared and hate myself for not being like the dudes in the posters-

At the time it was just a bunch of angry men like me grunting and throwing weights around- most of them were on steroids- I never did steroids as I was naive and thought all my favorite bodybuilders like Arnold were all natural so I would be too-

At my biggest I weighed 240 pounds and had 19 inch arms but I was afflicted by body-dysmorphia so I saw myself as a tiny skinny little man with boney arms even though I looked like a bear-

No matter how big or bulky I got it was never good enough- I was still tiny and weak- because mentally- I was tiny and weak-

I was so unbalanced and obsessed-

How insecure was I?

I felt threatened by the size of the arms of obese old women- I'm not even joking-

I'd see the fat hams hanging through the arm hole of some oversized ladies shirt and be all " are her arms bigger than mine?! " and I was %100 serious-

I knew their arms were not pure muscle- but still- the sheer size of them impressed and intimidated me-

I was obviously not in a right state of mind because thats just hilarious to me now- but back then I really felt threatened by the jiggly guns of overweight grandma's-

I 'd stare at them sweating- shaking- "shit bro, are those guns bigger than my guns" I'd think-

They were destroying my reality- I need to work out more bro- make my guns bigger- I mean, it was ok for men to have bigger arms than me- they were men-

But grandma's had bigger guns than my guns bro?! What the fuck!? How could this happen? Brooooooooooooo!

The grandma's would be walking around minding their own business but to me it was a competition- a war- I was at war with every sleeveless grandma I'd see-

I'd be like "my guns are bigger than her's and her's and"

Then BOOM some 400 pound old lady would appear like a rare Pokemon that ate too much gravy- it was as if this grandma said to me "what now bitch? Look at my massive guns little man! What you got bitch!"

I would sneak looks at them and cower- then go back to the gym and work out harder- I had to beat these fucking grandma's at least! These grandma's with their guns they flaunt all over the place- they were destroying my fragile buffed man world-

I thought being a big buffed man was the manliest straight man thing you could be- these manly men were all around me flexing and posing- they were in the locker room naked- flexing and posing- critiquing each others muscles with they dicks flopping all over the place- so many floppy dicks bro- we're so manly.

Later I learned from a family member that worked at Worlds Gym in Venice California that a lot of the big famous buffed men down there that I read about in magazines did "private posing sessions" for male patrons as an extra source of income. Learning that- and that they were all juiced to the gills with every nuclear steroid they could get their hands on changed my perspective on the whole thing.

There were a few characters in the gym that I went to every day that stood out- every gym has the guy that's too loud and the guy that sweats everywhere and they guy that asks you to spot him and makes you do all the work- but we had some special ones-

ALL AMERICAN OLD MAN

There was the old guy- I'd say around 70- he had this constant scowl on his face- this manly angry look- everything out of his voice came out as a grunt- angry- manly-

He was so fucking manly he acted like he was in constant pain because of it- grunting- cussing- being angry- like fuck this gay earth- its not up to my manly standards- its such a pain just to exist in this pansy bullshit! Raaaaaaahhhh!

He'd wear an american flag do-rag, an american flag bodybuilding shirt, american flag bodybuilding pants and bodybuilding shoes-

We called him "All American Old Man" He was always pissed- "fuck this- fuck that" flying out of his mouth or he'd say "Son of a bitch" after taking a drink of water from the fountain because the water was too fucking sweet and soft for his sour hardcore mouth-

He was always the loudest guy in the gym so you always knew where he was "rah rah rah huhaaaaaah" you'd hear echoing off the high walls covered by photos of muscle people and large mirrors- he seemed to always be there and was sort of part of the ambience- he was just in the background cursing and grunting but you never really paid attention to him- I did pay attention to him once-

I was doing leg extensions which sat right in front of the leg press machines- I had head phones and on this day I wanted to see what All American Old Man really did- he lurched around the leg press machine with these big tight knee wraps around both knees that made you walk in Frankenstein-

So there he was lurching around like Frankenstein's angry grandpa on steroids- grunting and cursing under his breath like a real man- angry- "son of a bitch" as he loaded hundred pounded plates onto the machine- "god damn it" as he loaded more and more hundred pound plates on the machine till it was maxed out- which was about 1000 pounds-

He grunted and looked around the gym but no one was paying attention except for me- I'm a sneaky fuck so he didn't notice that I was- he grunted and cussed for a bit as I watched- then he picked up an olympic bar and put it over the machine and started adding 45 pound plates to that- he lurched back and forth cussing occasionally letting out a loud " raaaaah" then looked around- no one cared- he eventually put about 400 pounds on the bar so that machine was loaded with about 1500 pounds- " rahhh rahhh" he screamed out while pacing back and forth like a big cat with stupid looking baggy clothes covered in american flags-

He slammed down into the the leg press machine seat after re-wrapping his knees with the knee wraps for ten minutes cursing under his breath- "fuck" he yelled out as I watched this powerful man- this angry man full of masculine rage-

He sat in the seat now letting out a long loud roar " Raaaaaaahhhhhhhhhhh" it was so loud and so ridiculous that nearly everyone in the gym turned to see what was happened- Had a T-rex been let loose in the gym? Did a hundred pound plate crush some dudes balls? Would this mirrors all shatter from the power of his masculine roar? Would the walls come tumbling down and ruin my set of leg extensions?

Everyone looked over at him- saw the massive weight on the machine and nodded with an "oh shit bro thats pretty heavy bro" He kept yelling as I watched- he hadn't lifted the weight yet- he was just sitting there yelling " Rah rah rahhhhhh"

he just kept yelling for so long people eventually looked away going back to their own workouts with headphones on- he seemed pleased that the whole gym had looked over at him-

I watched him and he continued grunting- not lifting any weight yet- then he just got up cursing- He sneaked a few looks around to make sure no one was looking- they weren't- well, except for me.

He started taking the weights off the machine- I watched him unload all the weight and walk away still cursing like a manly man who makes a bunch of noise- all talk and no action… man.

There was another guy at the gym that was really tall and fat- he thought he was so super buffed that he walked with his arms really far from his sides like buffed guys do- but this guy was ridiculous- his arms were so far out it looked like he was driving a car with a really big steering wheel when he walked-

Ee called him The Cadillac Driver- he turned sideways to walk through doorways instead of just lowering his arms- too fucking buffed bro- I can't walk through a door like a normal man can- go sideways driving my cadillac yo-

I nearly died a few times as this other tall pudgy guy with a sex offender mustache would always ask me to spot him- "excuse me can you spot me" he'd say-

Spotting a stranger is something you had to do if you were manly enough too bro! " fuck this guy" I would think as he would ask but I had to be a cool gym bro so I always said yes- he would load up the bench press with way more weight then he could do himself- so I pretty much curled it for him- then the nerve of this fucking guy- he'd always go "five more" or " three more" when I was doing all the work practically dying trying to

curl 275 pounds for him- then when it was over I was breathing hard and sweating he'd pop up from the bench all proud of himself with this " wow I'm so strong " surprised look on his face- fuck that guy! 15 years later I saw him in downtown San Jose- he's now homeless living next to a river- I spotted him there- see what I did?

There was another guy I always watched in dismay- this guy wore a football jersey- skinny to average build guy in a football jersey-ok there's nothing wrong with that- now mind you this was on indoor weight lifting gym- there was no grass- no field- it had clean hard gym floors- this guy worked out in cleats- yes the shoes with metal spikes to get traction on grass- he wore them inside of Golds Gym as he ran sprints in the aisles between weight racks and machines- and it gets better- to top it off- there was one more thing he needed to wear inside of the gym day or night-

He was wearing eye black- yes the stuff football players wear to minimize glare from the sun- I guess the lights in there were too bright as dumb bells rained down from the ceiling he needed to look up and catch? I have no idea- but all these dudes were there- the jersey he always wore had the name "Ford" on the back so that was his name to me-

I spent so much time in that gym- but it was worth if if I wanted to ever be able to walk the street proudly with arms bigger than any morbidly obese women I would encounter in a big gun showdown that only I knew about- that was important bro!

My body dysmorphia stopped in my last year of college when I had to take tennis and volleyball classes. I bumbled around like a bloated buffoon- it was then when I realized- these giant useless muscles are totally useless unless a car or heavy tree falls directly on top of me then I would be able to push it off

and get all the chicks- the car or tree opportunity never came but these skinny dudes stomped my ass in tennis and volleyball- a bigger threat than any gun from any obese grandma! I had to rise to a new challenge of being able to walk without having my inner thighs chafe from my massive quads bro- a new world in which you didn't sweat with the stink of eye watering ammonia from consuming too much protein awaited-

MASTER TAO

Some times I wonder how I'm still alive today with all the dumb shit my friends and I did when we were kids- we even joined a hindu Kung Fu sex cult once on accident!

I was about 14 at the time- sitting at home when my best friend Bobby called me on the phone- " hey what are you doing?" he asked " nothing, why?" I answered " So I met this guy and he knows all this stuff- he says he knows you and he wants to meet you- he's here right now- can you come over?" he asked " Ok" I said and left the house- I

As I walked into Bobby's house I saw this short intense man I had never seen before " Michael- hello Michael its nice to meet you" he said with an odd intensity in his eyes that freaked me out a little- "I've heard a lot about you" he said as he looked down at my t-shirt which was a Jimi Hendrix shirt- the album art from his album Axis: Bold as Love- " That's why he died " the man said- "what?" I asked " thats why he died- because he put his face in the place of god's" he added-

Now today if anyone said that to me today I'd check them into wack job land- but back then- with this older man talking to us- we didn't have many older men we respected talking to us as our fathers were not around- our fathers we're not there- this strange man was here in Bobby's house and we were talking to him

"My name is Tao- master Tao" he said as he reached out to shake my hand- a firm grip and a burning stare came with it "Are you two interested in learning martial arts" he asked us- Bobby and I looked at each other- of course we did- I mean

everybody wanted to be a ninja pretty much or thought they already were one - “ I can teach you Shaolin Kung Fu “ he said-

Oh shit, Shaolin Kung-fu?! We’d pretty much be in Wu-Tang clan- of course we wanted to learn “ yes “ we both said- “ ok I’ll by here at 6pm tomorrow- meet me here “ Master Tao shook our hands and left the house- Bobby and I looked at each other wondering what had just happened- “ Who is this guy?” I asked “ I don’t know- I was at the park playing basketball and he just started talking to me- he knew my name and who I was- and he knew you were my friend and what your name was “ he said-

Later I learned that this man would go to neighborhood parks and chat up kids- asking them who other kids were- and what their name’s were- thats how he found out about us- but we didn’t know that yet- we didn’t know that Master Tao had other ideas in mind for us other than teaching us Shaolin kung-fu in back bedrooms and empty lots- places absent of other adults-

GARY BUSEY WING CHUNNIN AT ME

As we waited the following day for Master Tao to return we heard a knock at the door- it was Tao with an older man in toe that looked like the actor Gary Busey- “this is Tao” Tao said “ Hi Lando” Bobby and I answered- Tao looked around Bobby’s small apartment “ Is your mom home?” he asked- “ No- no one is home “ Bobby said as I waited to become a ninja. “ its $25 per month for these lessons so ask your mom for the money when she comes home “ said Tao “ ok “ said Bobby-

Now it may seem like we are all zombies around Tao at this point simply agreeing with everything he said- never questioning him- I can understand how cult members can follow wackos to do weird shit because the charismatic cult leader types like Tao have a way about them wherein you never question them until they are gone then you ask yourself “ why did I agree to do that?! “

“ I’m building an army of soldiers” Tao said “ One day I will call upon you to fight for me and you will fight for me “ he added- I just wanted to be in the boy scouts myself or maybe a baseball team but this weird cult leader guy and Gary Busey were all I got so I was all in- hell yeah I’ll fight who know’s who in some battle as these men were talking to me about cool shit and I desperately wanted to be a part of something cool and have a man I respected pay attention to me-

There were no dad’s around to say “who the fuck is this guy?! Hell no you’re not going with him” but we didn’t have dad’s around to say that so we went with this crazy fuck-

I know now who “Master Tao” is and what did before we met him because I just found one of the court documents online- I now know what he did to some of us and other a lot of other boys- but we’ll get to that-

Tao showed us a bunch of ridiculous impractical kung fu moves he has us practice in that small apartment until we were shirtless and sweating- Lando practicing with us- who the fuck was Lando anyway? Fucking Gary Busey whippin wing chun wrists at my face?!

After finishing our kung fu practice of kicks, punches, blocks and the like- he asked Lando to leave- so Lando left- he asked us to come into one of the bedrooms with him so we did- he told us " I'm about to initiate you both into a secret order- as I say this your names are being written into stone (at so and so temple at a place I don't remember)"

Then he said some stuff in a language I didn't understand- it could have just been gibberish but we repeated it as he told us too then we we're apparently part of some secret important organization-

He asked us to take a walk with him- so we did- in the middle of the walk he stopped in front of us- hands behind his back like he often did to share some wisdom with us- we watched him closely as he asked " have you ever seen a proper dragon tail with tiger claw in the full moon? " or something like that- " no " I answered as he leapt three feet into the air- spinning with a jump kick- flipping like a gymnast- -swift feet and fists flew past us- then he landed frozen in a cool pose- he paused for a second as we held our breaths- he looked back at us " now you have" he said as he continued walking as if nothing ever happened-

He would do things like that- that left us in awe and made us think they he really like the kung fu master we had seen in the movies- he ended up being like some guys I've been in movies- but not in the kung fu ones- the weird documentaries about cult leaders and sexual abuse-

These physical feats he did also intimidated us- it made me feel like he was dangerous- a dangerous kung fu master that could kick the shit out of me-

IT'S NOT WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

We had kung fu practice with Master Tao about three times a week- it was always at different places- usually school yards or parks at night and there was always different kids and men with us- never any girls or women-

One night we were walking through a school on our way to practice when we all stopped in front of a small enclave near a classroom door- there was something moving there in the dark- undulating- but it didn't register in my mind what it was-

Tao stood frozen staring at the undulating mass of humanity- then it hit me- it was two people having sex on the dirty cement floor- a large woman on top of a skinny man- Bobby and I looked over at each other laughing hysterically with our eyes- not wanting to laugh in front of our almighty kung fu teacher-

Tao walked up the undulating mass slowly and stopped- " excuse me- you shouldn't be doing this here" he said in a calm voice " oh my god!" the woman screamed as she leapt up pulling her pants up " its not what it looks like " she barfed- Yeah lady we didn't just see that skinny guy with the sunglasses who is now standing up lighting a cigarette like people in the movies do after having sex- we didn't just see his penis going in and out of you- no you must have fallen down and was accidentally impaled by his penis and tried to get up several times to no avail- yeah its not what it looks like-

She kept babbling as she ran off behind the smoking man- Tao turned and walked into the center of the school and we began kung fu practice on the faded blacktop-

REPLACEMENT DAD SAYS NO TO GIRLS

There were two new kids with us practicing with us that night- Bobby and I recognized them from the local basketball court but we had never talked to them- we all did want Tao said in that dark school yard as we always did- Twenty crescent kicks- fifteen pushups…..

I was 15 years old at this time- I hadn't gone back to high school yet so I didn't have any friends outside of Bobby- so Tao gave us something to do- he took the place of the adult man that wasn't there in our lives at the time- my dad- mentally ill off in some hospital somewhere- Bobby's dad had left his mom for another woman and was living somewhere else with her and his new family-

So we practiced with Tao- paid our monthly dues- occasionally he'd have us play basketball with him or take a walk around the city- on one such walk I went with him alone as Bobby was starting to flake out on kung fu practice as have just gotten a girlfriend-

Tao expressed his disappointment with Bobby " wasting his potential" he said by being with a girlfriend- he doted on me as " being focused and not being distracted by girls " he would say- I wanted to make Tao proud so it made me happy to hear such things from him- yes I was disciplined so I wouldn't be distracted by girls I would think back then-

I followed Tao on a long walk to the other side of town one Sunday- every time we came across a major bus stop, community center or park he seemed to know kids there- boys- it seemed that he knew boys all over the town as they would come over to say hi to him-

After our long walk wherein he talked as I listened- following him, we got onto a bus for the long ride home- we were sitting in the back of the bus- me next to him- he had just finished telling me how proud he was of me for not giving into to girls when a girl a little older than me came over from the front of the bus and sat next to me-

She was attractive girl with dark hair and black nail polish- “whats your name?” she asked “ Michael “ I said- she smiled and looked me “ your really cute, I like you” taken aback as no girl had ever come up to me and told me things like this out of the blue before- she looked me in the eye then pointed down there street “ I live right over here- do you want to come to my house” she asked with a smile- I looked over at Tao then back to her “ no thank you “ I answered- looking back at Tao for the nod of approval that he then gave me “ok she said well my name is (forgot her name) I hope I see you again” she said with a smile- returning to her seat- she got off at the next stop smiling and waving to me as she did so-

Neither I nor Tao said anything else but I felt proud that I had turned down this strange attractive girl that approached me- I was sure that this Tao with his mysterious powers had set this situation up to test me- and I had passed- Thats what I thought at the time- I learned much later on why he didn’t want me to get involved with girls and that the only power he had was the power to manipulate people into doing that he wanted-

BREAKING NECKS FOR SHRIMP

I'm now 16- having just returned to high school- now I had something to do during the week- The phone rang late one Monday night- it was Tao- something had happened and he needed Bobby and I to assist him- I looked at the clock- 10pm- he told me he was going to pick Bobby and I up to meet at Bobby's house- I wanted to say no because I had school the nest day but he had a way to stop you from saying no- so I agreed to meet-

He picked us up in a blue sedan- we got in and sat quietly as we waited for him to tell us what was so important- He looked at us and looked like he was going to speak then paused as he often did- after the pause he smiled then began to speak "one of my students has done something really unacceptable" he said- Bobby and I looked at each other wondering what this kid had done " he's done something really bad and we have to punish him " he added- "punish him?" I thought- half terrified as to what we might have to do and half excited to finally test out my new deadly ninja skills I had learned throwing crescent kicks in elementary school yards at night with Gary Busey and company-

" If I ask you to break his arms, will you break his arms" he asked us- Bobby and I looked at each other then both answered " yes we will " He nodded as we pulled into a neighborhood across town I had never been in- " His mom called me and told me that he had hit her- thats unacceptable, we have to punish him " he said- Ready to kill- Ready to die- Bobby and I sat in the back of that blue sedan waiting to be called upon like attack dogs on whoever he tells us to assault-

We pulled up in front of a dark house- all the lights were out- he stopped the car and motioned for us to get out as he

crept up to a glowing window on the garage- looked in- then walked back towards us " my student broke up with his girlfriend- then got angry and hit his mother- thats unacceptable- he's in the garage- take a look" he whispered-

Excited to see what was going on in there I crept up to peer into the small glowing window on the beige garage- as I approached the sound of sentimental music faded up- I recognized this song- it was LL Cool J's " I need love " a song I knew but couldn't seriously listen to as I was still too tough a fart juice drinking tough boy-

Bobby and I self identified as hardcore tough boys- we listened to NWA , Public Enemy and the DOC not LL cool J's "I need love" I got on my tippy toes and looked through the window into the garage- a shrine of flickering candles around the photo of a girl- a small boombox next to it- "I need love" playing- a boy about the same age as us kneeling next to the photo candle shrine- head in hands sobbing- I wanted to laugh at the scene but I knew I might have to kill him so I had to try and act hardcore-

BOOM BOOM BOOM Tao banged on the front door- " Let me in Robby!" Tao barked as the kid got up from his I need love pity party shrine and ran out of the garage BOOM BOOM BOOM Tao banged on the door again- Bobby and I looked over at each other waiting for what would come next- what would come next? Were we going to have to kill this kid? Would he come out with a gun and kill us? Would Tao kill him? We had no idea- we followed Master Tao blindly because it seemed like we had no choice not too-

Tao dug into his pocket and pulled out a key- he had a key to this kids house? Why did he have a key? The door popped open and we rushed into the house after Tao- " why did you do this Robby" Tao barked as we heard a smack as we pushed into

the kids dim bedroom- the kid Robby was sitting on his bed crying as Tao stood over him-

We stood at either side of Tao like attack dogs waiting for commands- " why did you do this Robby!?" Tao barked again- " I don't know! I'm sorry " Robby said- crying- " You must never do anything like this ever again Robby you hear me! " he shouted down at Robby- " If you do I'll come back with Mike and Bobby and if I command them to break your arms or break your legs they will break your arms and break your legs " he yelled as we leaned forward, pushed by a strange force that you could feel pricking up the hair on the back of your neck with this feeling- a surge of power to enforce Tao's law-

Robby cried never looking up at us- " yes Tao I'm sorry, I'm sorry" he said " Good, now clean yourself up " Tao said as he pointed towards the kids bathroom as his face was now covered with snot and tears- this kid needed love for sure but all we brought was fear and hate- adrenalin still pumping, we followed Master Tao into the kitchen- the kitchen lights were on now- glasses clanged as the kids mom- an attractive woman in her late 30's with short black hair- large breasts flailing around inside of her loose shirt sans bra- "You boys want shrimp?" She chirped in an inviting and upbeat tone- What was going on now? I thought as she walked towards us with a shrimp platter and glasses in her hands- " Hey Tao" she said-

"Doesn't this lady know that we were about to kill her son?" I thought- for whatever reason she was fine and happy as she sat us down and served us shrimp and ice water- Tao stood behind us with his arms crossed silent " these are some nice looking boys Tao " she said as she looked us over running her hands up and down my arms as I sat there in her kitchen eating her shrimp right after I wanted to kill her son for nothing- Bobby and I were dumbfounded- what the fuck was going on?!

We were getting ready to kill this kid and now what? Is he going to tell us to bang this lady whose big bouncing boobs we couldn't keep are pubescent eyes off of? We sat there for a few minutes eating shrimp as this woman watched us " We have to go" Tao said as we stood up and followed him out- as we did the woman kissed Tao on the cheek and said goodbye as we sat in the car waiting in the shadows to do whatever he told us to do next.

Love songs, violence, tears, threats, intimidation, tits, and shrimp? I think one of the reasons we always went with Tao is because you never knew what to expect- he always took you on these weird adventures- of course this was before we knew what he was really about-

MASTER TAO'S SPECIAL STRETCHING SESSIONS

At this point I had school to deal with and Bobby had school and a girlfriend but we still came most every time Tao called- one of the things he called me over to the room he rented was for "stretching sessions" is what he called them- he told me " you're getting really flexible Mike- if we did some private stretching sessions I could really help you- you would be able to do the splits" he said-

It made total sense at the time and didn't seem sketchy at all- and who didn't want to be able to do the splits like Jean Claude Van Damme? I went to maybe two of three of these private sessions that he gave me- alone in the dark room he rented with cash- under a fake name- I later learned- There were pictures of Krisna on the wall- a mostly empty room that didn't look lived in-

The first time I showed up- the smiling face of the teenage girl who parents owned the house he rented a room from answered the door " Hi " she said as a smile pushed the limits of her teenage face- " Hi I'm here to see Master Tao " I said "Who?" she said as Master Tao walked up from behind her " he's here to see me " Tao said as she stepped aside and watched me walk in past her.

He would tell me to lay on the floor then for the next 30-60 minutes as we'd roll around on the floor as he did stretching exercises on me- he never straight up grabbed my genitals- he sort of rubbed on them with his leg or the back of his hand a few times and he counted off from ten to one as he ran through his stretching exercises-

I just went through the discomfort imagining myself doing spin jump kicks like Van Damme with my new found skills- it seemed to take forever- I paid close attention to boners-

making sure I never got a boner and that he never got one either as that was my out plan- if he got a boner or if I got one I was out of there- no boners ever occurred so these were always just weird stretching sessions to me as they did seem to make my legs more flexible- this weird little ninja dude just enjoyed being sorta close to my dick as he counted and moaned-

A BOY AND HIS DOG

I did know the two brothers who lived in the house Tao rented a room from- the girl that answered the door was their sister- the younger brother was the same age as me and we had played in his backyard a few times when we were nine or ten- I “met” the other brother when I was twelve-

I was playing baseball with some friends on a local baseball field- I was about to pitch the ball to my friend when I felt a pressure on my left calf- I looked down and there was this dog biting my leg as blood dripped down my high white socks “ get off! “ I yelled as I kicked the dog away- it ran back to a kid who was kneeling near the baseball fields backstop- he had a baseball hat on and looked about 18 with a thick puberty mustache on his face- as the dog ran back to him he pet it “ gub boy “ he said with a heavy speech impediment “ dude! what the hell?! your dog bit me! “ I yelled at him as he pet the dog - ignoring me- talking softly to the dog “ gub boy “ he said as he stroked the dogs back-

I looked over at my friends- they didn’t know what to do either- we didn’t want to keep playing if this guy was going to sick his dog on us or if it was going to bite someone else so we just stood there looking at him- he started to pat the dogs back faster and faster then he reached over and dug into a faded blue backpack that he had on the ground next to him- we all watched in horror at what happened next-

As he had one hand on the dog petting its back we didn’t notice that the dog had a bright pink erection- but this kid did- so with his other hand he reached into his backpack and I shit you not- he pulled out a piece of what appeared to be bologna the same stuff that poor kids would fry up like it was some great delicacy in our neighborhood- he pulled the bologna and and started to masturbate the dog with it- right there in the

middle of the baseball field in broad daylight- “ goob boy “ he said softly to the dog as he vigorously stroked its sharp pink dog dick- “ what the fuck dude?! “ I said half amazed and half horrified- I didn’t know whether to laugh or puke so we all laughed- we pointed and laughed as the kid stroked the dog faster and faster occasionally shooting a glance at one of us to make sure we weren’t going to interrupt the act or something- “ Gub boy- gub boy “ he continued to say to the dog as we laughed

“Stanley! What are you doing“ a voice from across the street yelled- the kid heard it and threw the bologna off to the side- His younger brother was the one doing the yelling as he approached the baseball field- the kid stood up and walked toward him with the dog as if nothing had happened- as the younger brother started yelling at him in a foreign language I didn’t understand- the younger brother was the one I used to play with years earlier- he didn’t say anything to us- instead he shot a glance over like “ I’m sorry guys “ before he took his mentally retarded brother home that enjoyed masturbating his dog in public with pieces of lunch meat- those were the children of the people who owned the house Tao rented a room from-

I BROKE MY OWN FACE TO ESCAPE MASTER TAO

The next time I returned the girl answered the door again- as I sat in the room waiting for his moaning counting stretching thing that will get me closer to Van Damme status " the girl who lives here, Darlene- she asked me to tell you that she likes you and wanted me to give you her phone number" he said handing me a slip of paper with a girls handwriting on it- Girls were a distraction Tao said-

I took the paper but showed no interest as I sincerely was dedicated to Tao's cause and wanted to make him proud- the dad I never had rubbing my balls and moaning in the back room telling me not to talk to girls my age- a great father figure he was-

So there I was- dedicated kung fu disciple getting my junk rubbed in a back room ignoring attractive girls my age- waiting for Tao to call- he did call- this time he invited us to dinner- he was going to take us to a buffet on the other side of town to reward us for our loyalty- we agreed and he picked us up in his squeaky blue sedan- the one thing I remember about this night is the music- he played the Whitney Houston song from the movie "The Bodyguard" on repeat the whole time over and over " and IIIII will always love you" over and over and over-

He talked about defeating crowds of armed men and about the evils of girls to us over dinner- other than that it was not memorable- on the way home "I will always love you" still repeating on the car stereo as we got pulled over by the police- as soon as the lights flashed behind us- he told us " the police will take me and I'll be gone for a few days then I will come back" we nodded- and sure enough the police handcuffed him and took him away- now there we were with the police- they didn't ask us why we were with this man- they didn't ask us

what we were doing with him- they just told us to get in the back of one of their cars- we were far from home on the other side of town- the police drove us to a 7 eleven convenience store not far from where they had stopped us and let us out- we were minors with this strange man that they arrested- they told us nothing about why they arrested him and they asked us no questions- they just dropped us off at a 7 eleven- I called my mom- she picked us up and took us home-

A week or so after being arrested Tao was back and we were at Bobby's house training- we were training crescent kicks- with those kicks you kind of swing your whole leg in a half circle in front of your own face- I was getting really flexible from training- from his private stretching sessions too? I thought so at the time-

I had my nose broken by a bully a few years before so I knew what it felt like- as I was throwing crescent kicks with my newfound flexibility- I was a little too overzealous and a little too flexible as my knee came by my face I heard the familiar snap of a broken nose " I broke my nose" I yelled out as I grabbed it and felt it out of place- I pushed it back instantly into place with my nose in my hands-

I remembered the months of recovery after a doctor had to re-break my nose the first time because I waited too long to go to the doctor and I didn't want to repeat that ever again with the yards of snotty bloody gauze they packed up my nose- the sore throats- the trouble breathing- all of that flashed through my mind when I snapped it back into place- everyone stopped practicing as Tao walked over to me and looked at my nose " Its not broken" he said-

I remember being shocked at the lack of concern he showed toward me that time- "its not broken, your fine- keep training " he said- " No its not, I broke it- I snapped it back into

place “ I said as blood began to trickle out of my nose “ see I told you, I broke it- I have to go “ I said as I put my shirt back on packing up my stuff rushing out the door half betrayed at Master Tao who seemed to not care that I was hurt-

I rushed home and told my mom who quickly took me to the hospital- the doctor came and examined my nose “ yes you did break it “ he said in front of the bluish glow of the X-ray “ you have a future in medicine because you reset it perfectly- there’s nothing more we can do- you did a good job “ he said with a smile- I was happy- “ how did you do this? “ he asked- “practicing Kung fu” I answered “ well you don’t do that anymore- I’d stay away from that for at least a month“ he said “Can I still play baseball“ I asked- worried about losing my spot on my new team wherein my teammates didn’t rub my dick- they just slapped my ass but thats a whole other thing specific to baseball- My mom nodded “ no more kung fu Michael “ she said, like concerned mom’s do- I was relieved because I wouldn’t have to go through the re-break procedure and I was relieved that I had a reason not to train with Master Tao anymore as it was starting to become a burden on my new teenage life.

The following week I told Master Tao that the doctor said that I couldn’t train anymore- he tried to convince me that I should but my fear of the nose break experience was greater than my fear of Master Tao- so I stood strong-

Shortly after that Bobby dropped out too- Tao still called but I started to avoid him- if he called I’d ask my mom or sister to tell him I wasn’t there- he kept calling and calling and showed up at my house a few times- by then I had a girlfriend and friends and was playing baseball- I had no time for my kung fu dreams anymore-

One day as I had taken a trip with my high schools girls softball team to an all girls school for an away game as teenage boys like to do-

I started a conversation with a kid who lived in that neighborhood on the south side of town- the predominately white “nicer side of town”

We got talking about martial arts- I mentioned Master Tao- this kid knew who he was and said that he was training kids in this neighborhood too- “how many students does he have?” I wondered- then the kid proceeded to tell me that he heard a story from someone else that knew Master Tao in New York- and in the story Master Tao was being chased by the police and he had jumped off a tall bridge onto concrete- landing on his feet like a cat to get away from them- who was this man?! I wondered- I was going to find out who he really was soon enough-

He wasn’t a big man- he was only about 5’4” but what was impressive about him was how he moved- he moved with a certain grace and power like you would imagine a martial arts master would- when we would go play basketball we were impressed that a guy of his height could “dunk” on a regulation rim- so he was only 5’4” tall but he could easily dunk a basketball on a 10’ rim- none of us could dunk on a 10’ rim so it was just another thing he did that impressed us-

I was walking home from school one day when I saw two kids I had trained with- they were with us and Master Tao when we caught the people having sex in public- I now knew their names- Gary and Andre but I had never talked to them-

I walked up to them “ Are you still training with Master Tao “ I asked- they looked at each other “ No “ Gary said “ Are you?” he asked “ No not anymore “ I answered- “ You heard about Tao right “ Andre said raising his eyebrows “ No- heard what?” I asked- “ You heard about him and Nathan right? “ he said- Nathan was another kid whose name I knew because he had been with us and Tao but I had never talked to him-

Master Tao did this thing wherein he would introduce you to other boys- but he would never leave you alone with them to talk amongst yourselves- it seemed like he wasn’t interested in us making new friends- they were his friends- “ So Nathan called the cops “ Andre said “ For what?” I asked- “ Nathan said that Tao told him he was gonna teach him the drunken style you know like the Jackie Chan movies? “ he said- as I nodded my head- “ Then he said Tao got him drunk and raped him- he’s a fuckin child molester dude- he’s on fugitive watch “ he added-

I was stunned- shocked- but why was I? “ I went over to his place for stretching sessions like three times “ I said “ Yeah so did I “ Greg added- “ He never did anything like that to me- acted kinda weird though” I said “ Yeah man the cops are looking for him so yeah fuck Tao “ Greg said- We stood there for a bit chatting about other stuff- three teenage boys without dad’s-

I turned on the TV channel that played “Fugitive Watch” a local show that displayed wanted criminals in the area- it showed their image and described their crimes- shortly after turning it on there he was wanted for “Sodomy” and something else in relation to a minor- I’ve since found the files online describing his crimes from the court proceedings-

When we were with him riding around in his car he had already served time for raping and molesting boys- he was already a registered sex offender for raping boys which makes

me wonder why the police didn't tell us anything and just dropped us off at a convenience store?!

He was on parole at the time and has since raped a few others and is incarcerated- Here's something from the online court documents " According to the minor, defendant offered to show him a "secret ... He called himself "Master Tao," and described himself as a Hindu master. ..... after serving a prison sentence for raping a hitchhiker, Ward tried to rape an …"

So we had let a child molester and rapist into our homes- we paid him to teach us nonsense- we had spent long periods of time alone with him alone- we trusted him- we were ready to kill for him- we wanted his respect- we wanted him to tell us that we were good boys- we wanted him to tell us that we were going to be good men- we wanted his protection and guidance- we wanted everything from him that a father would give to a son- but in that fatherless inner city vacuum this child molester had shown up and spun his web catching many of us in it-

He never tried to rape me- he just rubbed my junk a bit and moaned- but I don't know what happened to the other boys- to my other friends that "trained" with him- I feel lucky that it didn't happen to me and feel sad for the ones it did happen too- I'm sure for every kid that told someone what he did to them there's ten more who didn't-

LOOK AT MY FACE DOG

When I got out of college- I was making films with whoever I could find- making music- being a nobody rapper like everybody else around here- On Friday nights a few friends and I would play projected video games on top of this parking garage downtown-

I was standing against the cement railing on top of a parking garage overlooking a street busy with foot traffic below- around this time is when the night clubs vomited people vomiting on to the street- they were also urinating and defecating as well as I learned from the security attendant that patrolled the federal building across the street who apparently aimed the surveillance camera on the hottest chicks taking dumps on the ground during his watch "hot chicks yeah they take dumps right there every weekend!" he said as he pointed into a corner semi obscured by a small tree inside of a circular bench. The dude seemed really excited about it- I don't know why-

Was he so excited by "hot chicks" that everything they did was exciting to him? Like, even the act of defecation was hot because they were hot? I don't know- weird dude-

I would often come up to the parking garage alone to watch the people- to see them scream and yell- walking awkwardly with oversized, ill fitting shoes- to see them shivering in the cold wearing next to nothing- to see men throwing their arms up in the air like crawdads, looking for a fight-

I did see a fight once from this very spot as a few friends and I had brought a projector, a laptop and some joysticks up to the top of the parking garage- we were playing a giant projected version of Street Fighter 2 on a wall when we

heard some slurred profanities from the street below- so we looked over the edge with giant idle street fighters bouncing back and forth on the wall behind us waiting for a fight- on the street below there was a skinnier guy stumbling around yelling and pointing at a big tall burly guy- the skinny guy craw-dadded throwing his arms up like crustacean claws- in a "whats up" gesture. The big guy stood his ground- the small guy inched closer eventually getting in the face of the big man-

We stood there leaning over the concrete edge a knurled steel cable vibrating as we pushed onto it trying to get a closer look- giant projections of Ken and Guile bouncing behind us waiting for action as the timer ticked down-

The skinny guy leapt in and threw a punch at the big guy- the big guy lurched back as the little guy flew into his face throwing a flurry of weak looking punches- more with his wrists than his fists- the big guy grabbed a hold of him and the skinny guy kept up the ineffective barrage of fists- the skinny guy had now gotten the big guy in a headlock as the big guy leaned over seemingly unfazed by this surprise crayfish assault force of skittering wrist claw fists-

In an instant the big guy had lifted the skinny guy into the air and with a rush of air and a loud dull meaty thud he slammed the skinny guy down onto the concrete an "OH SHIT" reverberating in all the onlookers minds- the big guy rolled over so that he was now on top of the skinny guy pummeling his face with his large fist- each one making a bright WAP sound- after 20 or so punches the big guy stood up- dusted himself off- pointed at the small guy and walked away-

All the while this was going on the police were watching from 60 feet away as they were manning a barricade to divert traffic- the big guy walked by the police and away into the night- eventually the small guy stumbled to his feet on shaky

legs with a bloodied and swollen face- unaware to our presence we kept watching him as he patted down his own pockets as if searching for a phone- he felt his face with his hands and shouted “FUCK” - he paced back and forth removing his shirt and sticking it into his back pocket- he walked towards the police as they raised a flashlight in his face- he walked back the other way directly underneath us as he cursed to himself- “motherfucker” he mumbled-

A crowd of nightclubbing women sauntered towards him as he limped up to the group- “let me use your phone- let me use your phone” he insisted as the women backed up and moved away- “let me use your phone” he insisted as they avoided him and kept moving forward saying nothing- So at this point “let me use your phone” was not effective at getting his point across- he needed a plea much more personal and much more persuasive-

He needed to touch their hearts and move their souls so they would let him use their smart phone so he could most likely call his friends so they could form a gang of raised claw crawdads to find the badman of that night to pummel and terrorize him and his friends- thereby giving purpose and focus to their lives for at least one night-

So with all this on the line- what passionate plea did he create? What persuasive prose that would no doubt make a call to a higher need- a higher cause- what did he come up with to touch these women’s heartstrings and move them to action?

He hobbled around the group and made his way directly in front of them stopping them in their tracks- he singled out one woman and pleaded with her while pointing with an outstretched finger at his own face- and this is what he said- this is his passionate plea for him and all of his friends to make life

matter for one more night- one more night of life- this is what he said-

"Look at me face dog! look at my face dog! let me use your phone dog! look at my face dog!" That was the best he could come up with that chilly night in downtown San Jose- So he reused the "let me use your phone" part but added "dog" on to it- a called to the women's inner thugs- a call to the dog with DMX's face on it inside of them- a call to their primordial I gotta get mine fuck you WOOF WOOF inner soul thug dog!

But that wouldn't be enough- he needed to make a human connection with them so that they knew this was a flesh and blood- blood of my blood real human thug dog in front of them- they could of mistaken him for a telephone phone or a mailbox if he didn't explicitly point as his own face that was less than two feet from their own faces they could of thought it was a flyer on a telephone pole talking- or even worse The police!

No, we in the hood- its me! Thug dog man! Look at my face dog! Its a face in front of your face and its bleeding real thug blood! Thug girls hear my call and respond to my call to action by lending me your magical smart phone so I can hollar at my distinguished boys so they can hastily come to my side and assist me in seeking out this badman that did this to my thug dog blood of my blood face!

Even with all this going for him his passionate plea topped off with "dog" fell on deaf ears. The woman stepped back as the group walked around him and continued to meander down the street toward the police barricade- the man turned to face the group of women throwing his hands up again like an aggressive crawdad "look at my face dog!" he screamed-

The loud static hiss of a police PA turning on " sir, put your shirt on" a stern voice of a policemen said in the tone of a

disapproving father- the man slowly lowered his crawdad fists and pulled the shirt out of his back pocket- The thug passion- the street magic was gone and dead- washed away by the stark reality of that policeman voice, the cold wind and the non responsive women to his thug dog cries.

He cursed to himself as he pulled the shirt back over his head- we watched him disappear into the oncoming crowd of clubbing drunks approaching in the opposite direction- we could see him cursing and flailing to himself before he was gone- we turned around and got back to our game- Street Fighter 2- I played as E Honda- my friend played as Vega- after beating Vega the screened flashed with his bloody beat up face as it does when you lose in Street Fighter 2- “look at my face dog!” I barked as we laughed playing our play fighting games as the real adults went home.

CLUCK OF DEATH

Out of college I lived in Santa Monica for a few years- made a few strange films there-

My friends in Santa Monica were an illegal Mexican immigrant who was a Sephardic Jew that I lived with and was my best friend- A frizzy haired crazy man who did writing on Leprechaun in the Hood and his wild eyed girlfriend raised by hippies named Pandora- a homeless artist and performer who become the star of many of my films even though he "didn't entirely love what we were doing" as he wanted to do serious work- he thought I was a serial killer because of my obsession at the time with Kit Kat's- "lets have Kit Kat's!" I would say leaping out of my seat at 3am to walk over to the gas station to get some Kit Kat's-

He was much more intelligent and aware than I was- He was an amazing improv actor, a talented musician and painter- a great writer- a really brilliant guy.

When I would want to go out for Kit Kat's he would say "what do you mean Mike?" " Lets go to gas station and get Kit Kat's" I would answer "Kit Kat's?! What does that mean?" he asked "You know Kit Kat's- the chocolate wafer things" I answered- he must of took me for a much more complicated man than I was.

He was homeless at the time so he would often crash at random peoples houses so I'm sure he was used to being around a bunch of creeps and freaks that used code words for their horrible fetishes and the people and things they committed crimes against- but no- I just wanted to get Kit Kat's- he would half heartedly agree and walk slowly behind me waiting for someone to leap out, kidnap and torture him-

I'd walk up to the gas station attendant and buy two Kit Kat's handing one to my talented homeless friend- he'd look at it puzzled as if there was some surprise in store- but there was none- he'd finally let his guard down "I guess we're just a couple of crazy guys having Kit Kat's eh?" he said as I smiled and walked back to the apartment.

Steven was his name- I called him Stevie- I loved that guy- he was one of the smartest and most talented people I've ever met- he was a wonderful comedian as well- but Stevie was a little too intelligent about things I believe- he would overthink things- doubt himself- doubt his ideas- overcomplicate things when he should have just enjoyed the Kit Kat's- without the desire to make it more than it was- if it was fun and was good and it worked than just leave it be- its ok- being stupid when you are really smart is a skill-

I considered Steve like a brother- a brother in the arts- he loved performing but I knew my ideas were a bit too strange for him- he enjoyed acting- but his face would contort as I explained my pitch for "Cluck of death" about a stop motion whole chicken- the kind that you would buy to cook and eat- a stop motion whole chicken that stalked and raped male bodybuilders-

I was laughing while explaining the details of how the chicken would masturbate with non existent hands or penis while watching the bodybuilders shower from outside their apartments before choking them to death with its missing limbs-

His contorted face was struggling for answers "why does this sick Kit Kat man want to make such a thing" I would imagine him thinking- a part of me enjoys making people feel that way- and thats why I've done what I've done- its fun to make people revile and bewildered- we never made cluck of death unfortunately- but it was fun watching Steve squirm in that

Mexican restaurant on the Santa Monica Promenade as I explained it to him.

“Thats good Mike” he would say like a big brother talking to his mentally retarded younger brother that wants to burn things.

Stevie didn’t know anything about my upbringing as a bad boy- to him my ideas seemed random, bizarre, shocking, repulsive-

Because of that I had experienced as a child my ideas seemed totally normal to me- they seemed funny-

I don’t know whatever happened to Stevie- last I heard he was living on the East Coast of Murica working as a caretaker for a man in a wheelchair and doing stand up comedy sets at hole in the wall bars.

Most everything I know about improvisation and acting I learned from watching and working with him- I’d like to have a coffee with him some time in the future- and a Kit Kat-

Stevie was a really good actor and he didn’t even have a business card- the really talented people rarely know how to market themselves-

WATER TOWER MC

Pathetic and hilarious are two words that describe my experience as a nobody rapper around other nobody rappers in San Jose California while I was in college-

There was a guy I called Uzi man that frequented a local freestyle open mic- he literally rhymed every other word he rapped with "Uzi"- here's an example-

"Then they see me with my Uzi- can't stop me- I'm blasting faster with my Uzi- My enemies can't lose me….. with my two Uzi's"

He'd go on like that bar after bar- I was giggling to myself while watching- just waiting for the next UZI to slip out-

There was no cursing allowed in that open mic- if you cursed more than once they'd cut off your mic. This helped lead to hilarity with Uzi man and this other rapper guy one night.

This other guy carried himself very seriously- he had the whole gangster/thug thing going on.

Uzi man was this skinny awkward looking white kid that worked at a Barnes & Noble cafe- I know this because he rapped about shooting his customers with his UZI-

What bitch? You don't like your coffee? Get back in line so I can spray you with my UZI!

So this serious gangster dude comes in and he's up in front of the crowd with Uzi man- right off the bat gangster man goes right at Uzi man to battle him-

"Muthafucka you be like.." he says as his mic is cut- the organizers of the show turn off the music then explain to him thats there's no cursing and that if he curses again he's booted from the show. He stops as Uzi man sees this as his opportunity.

"Look at me but you can't see me- perfect opportunity to blast you with my Uzi" Raps Uzi man- weak but to the point-

Gangster man shrugs it off and gets back on his mic- He paces back and forth and waves his arm as rappers do- he opens his mouth to rap-

"Look mutha….. " he pauses to regroup " you can't f….. you don't know shi" He pauses again unclear of what to say as he's clearly flustered and frustrated "muthafuhhhh….. the fuhhhh"

He kept cutting himself off before he cursed- realizing if he curses he'll be booted- but it seemed as if he had nothing to say if he couldn't curse which I thought was hilarious-

Now gangster man seemed like he had more skill/style than Uzi man's simple rhymes- but without the ability to curse it was like all of his guns had jammed while Uzi man was spraying UZI blasts non stop-

Seeing this weakness Uzi man went in for the kill-

"Me with my Uzi- fools can't see me- I sneak up behind them and blast through them completely" as he paused- building up momentum for his kill shot-

"WITH MY UZI" he screeched in his nasal voice as he pointed at gangster man with gun fingers.

Somehow with this simple wack rhymes Uzi man had defeated this back gangster man that needed to say muthafucka every other word lest he had nothing to say.

The defeated gangster man threw his arms up and frustration and stormed out of the place- never to return. Uzi man had prevailed with his trusty Uzi that day-

As funny as that Uzi man was- he was nowhere near as epic as a dude known as Water Tower MC or WTMC for short.

While I was in college I was really into making films but I didn't own any equipment yet- I had to borrow it from my uncle or my friends grandma- I was saving up for a new Apple computer which was a G4 model at the time- I knew everything about them and the creative software you could run on them to make music, and edit films and the like but I had never actually used one- I didn't have the money to buy one yet- I had an old Mac SE30 I got for $50 at a used Mac store but my neighbor had a new G4 because he was a rapper- as everybody was.

So I knew everything you could know about these computers without actually using them and he knew nothing about them but he owned one so we were a match made in heaven. I wanted to use one to uncover the awesome mysteries that must lie within to apply all my theoretical knowledge I gleaned from Apple marketing materials and he needed someone to fix it when something went wrong every week or so.

We were friendly neighbors saying hi to each other as we were close in age but we never actually hung out. He'd be having computer problems so I'd offer to try and fix them-

I'd go over to his house now and then to fix something on his Mac- he was a rapper- a gangster rapper- he used Cubase to record with but was saving up to get a Pro Tools setup- he had

other gangster rapper friends- one of which I remember particularly because he was a rich kid from a rich family and neighborhood- he usually acted the hardest of course- life is hard in a gated community up in the hills cause you know the gate to keep you safe could like- not work sometimes then you'd be trapped- gangsta thug dog blood of my blood BLAP BLAP for sure.

So at this time I wasn't rapping myself- I was just a fan who made instrumentals or beats as they are often called by messing with multiple tape decks- it was really remixing as I didn't have any real good gear or software yet to make my own stuff-

The first time I hung out with WTMC outside of fixing his computer in his house was when we took a ride to San Francisco to visit the music school he was going to at the time- it was a place to learn how to produce music- track- mix- master all that- visiting the school itself was uneventful- but as we got in the car to take the ride home he pulled something out of his pocket and spread some bluish crystalline dust on the steering wheel " this is just to keep me up so I don't fall asleep on the way home" he said as he snorted it off of the steering wheel " its just ice " he added. He got his pick me up and we drove home talking about rappers and computers-

I hung out with WTMC quite a bit- it was one of those things where while you were with them you thought to yourself " what am I doing here?" when they were snorting dope- but then afterwards you would have these crazy experiences because of the crazy shit they did- so it was a sort of morbid curiosity thing like " what the fuck is going to happen now?!"

At this time before I had a computer of my own I was already making short films and skits with my friends using borrowed equipment. WTMC had seen the videos and was

interested in hiring me to make a music video for one of his songs- years later when I did have my own gear I worked for a small video company making videos for local gangsta rappers- which was a whole other ball of fun and absurdity but for now lets stay on the water tower dog.

So one night as I was working on his computer he asked " hey you think you could shoot a music video for one of my songs " he said while taking hits from a small pipe " yeh for sure, I could make a video for you " I said as I genuinely loved the process- so I was happy to make anything for anybody " cool cool " he said blowing out quick puffs of smoke coughing and waving his arms " So I wanted to shoot it on that water tower right there" he said as he pointed to an old water tower a block away that is now only used to hold up twenty or so mobile network antennae's.

Being the true autist artist I was- I didn't laugh or scoff or even think of doing anything like that " well if you were going to do that you'd need to rent a helicopter to shoot that right " I said matter of factly- he took another hit of the pipe " how much does that cost" he asked " I don't know for sure- at least $50,000 " I said as his eyes bulged out with a cough- pausing for a second before answering " well couldn't we just shoot it from the ground" he asked-

I thought about it for a second as I rebooted his computer " well you could, but then you'd need a crane and a really good zoom lens which I don't have " I answered " how much would that cost?" he asked " hmmm I don't know, probably at least fifteen grand plus you would need to get the permits to shoot up there " I said as he paced back and forth " naw we wouldn't need any permits I could just climb up there and shoot it real fast- I could just climb up there and you could shoot it from the ground with the camera you have " he said " but if we did that with the camera I have you would look really

small- like it would barely be able to see you “ I said as he disappeared into another room quickly returning

“Well I’m just gonna be up there rapping with this gun right here” he said as he showed me his Glock 17 “ well ok, but it wouldn’t look very good- it would be too far away “ I said seeming to squash the idea about the music video- thats how the water tower MC name came about.

I hung out with WTMC because he was pretty fun and crazy and like- he did hard drugs some times but I never felt in danger around him- he had a a regular job, a good dad and a girlfriend- so outside of his wacky ass ideas about rapping on water towers his life was pretty stable.

AREA 187

Every time he called me asking about computer problems I'd walk over there and see what was up. Around that time I was reading a lot of books about U.FO.'s, aliens, mind control, secret societies and that sort of thing so in my reading I happened to mention to him that there might be a mysterious underground base in the hills above our city.

He just finished getting high so he was really interested " yeah its called Pratt and Whitney: United technologies space propulsion and chemical systems plant- its supposed to be where they make rocket engines but a few years ago me and my friends watched this orange orb thing that was floating over my friends house disappear into those hills so there's some shady shit going on over there" I said " have you ever been up there" he said with an intensity in his eyes " No, I've just read about it " I said " lets fuckin go dude- lets go up there and check it out " he said holding the intensity

"Ok- yeh lets go" I said as I shut his computer down. We walked outside and jumped in his car. The car was lowered or slammed as the kids said in those days and it had hella bass-

He wasn't a reckless or fast driver so I never felt unsafe being in the car with him even if he had just done a couple lines of ice. This time he was only high or at least thats what I saw him do. We drove through the north side- through the east side and got up to the base of the hills just as it had fallen dark. The base of the east hills in which the secret alien underground conspiracy illuminati base was.

Its sort of like farmland up where this mysterious place was so it was filled with rolling hills of long grass- sparse houses that are clustered together in uneven patterns with long distance

of nothing- then a bunch of houses- then nothing. He was driving slowly and scanning the road with intense bulging eyes- we were cruising along until my neck cranked forward suddenly and the car screeched to a half

"Oh shit" he yelped " did you see that?! Did you fucking see that?!" he barked " See what?" I asked " dude- oh shit dude- did you fucking see that?" he poured on " What the fuck man? What the fuuuuck?! " he continued as the car was stopped- rumbling in the middle of the dark road " did I see what? what did you see?" I asked with an urgency building as he put the car into reverse and slowly backed onto the side of the road- he sat for a second exhaling loudly-

I sat silently waiting for him to say something as I had no idea what he saw or what he was talking about- " what? what happened?" I asked " dude this is fucking crazy- shit man there really is something up here- you were right- you were fuckin right!" he barked " what? what did you see a UFO or what? What was it?" I asked as he open the drivers side door " hold on I'm going to get it- this is fucking crazy man " he leapt out of his door and ran behind the car talking to himself-

I turned around as far as I could without taking my seatbelt off trying to get a look at what it was-

He slowed and stopped- kneeling down next to something I couldn't make out on the side of the dark road- there were no street lights up there so the red tail lights of his car were the only light behind the car where he was-

I looked off into the dark woods surrounding us and back towards where he was kneeling- he slowly picked something up off the ground- his head darting back and forth checking to see if anyone was watching him- I sure was- he ran

back towards the car and jumped into the drivers seat cradling something in his arms.

He flipped his wrists over to show me the mysterious relic that he had discovered on the side of this dark road near the illuminati alien secret underground base.

“What the fuck man?! what the fuck is this?!” he said as he looked over the artifact tracing the grooves in it with his fingertips as if it was from some other world and his touch could damage it- or he could be damaged by touching it.

He carefully placed it onto the back seat “I’m taking this with me- need to run some tests on it” he said under his breath.

“Run some tests?!” I thought- shit, is this guy like a fucking scientist now?- he was making meth in his basement before Breaking Bad made it cool so maybe he was like a scientist and could really run elaborate tests to discover the true nature of this esoteric artifact that seemed to be a piece of a broken styrofoam cooler to me but what the fuck did I know?

I wasn’t a scientist that cooked meth and snorted ice- I didn’t even have a fucking album at that point- I wasn’t even a rapper yet.

After the artifact find I began thinking to myself “Hmm maybe this guy is a little paranoid? “ I wasn’t the sharpest guy at that time because anyone that has been around people using various drugs for any amount of time could tell you story after story in regard to the paranoid fantasies that high people had fabricated-

I didn’t need to hear those stories as I was living inside of one right now and I wanted to see what was going to happen-

maybe I could also find some shit to run some tests on? I mean there was bound to be some other roadside trash that should have met a recycle bin and not the hands of a paranoid gangsta rapper- could I even be a rapper?

I wasn't paranoid- do I need to be more paranoid? If I find something what tests would I run? I needed to start rapping asap and start some tests and shit and maybe then I could shoot a video on a bridge or a damn or underwater underneath a submarine with a team of dolphins wearing diamond grills with crack rocks for eyeballs acting as my hype cetaceans.

We drove around up on top of the hills where the base was for some time- there were a few "oh shits" and "what is that's" but nothing major- there was something up there as it was clear to see ventilation shafts coming up out of the ground but nothing mind blowing that could be seen from the surface- whatever was going on was going on beneath the surface-

I turned to look into the eyes of my friend- they had a burning intensity as if he could see and understand what was going on underneath the surface- he could see the conspiracy- he could see the secrets- he could see the ufo wreckage that looked like a broken styrofoam cooler to my non scientist eyes.

After driving around for 20 minutes or so we agreed to go back- we had already found the artifact that needed some tests to be run on so what more could we hope for after such a find? Perhaps a doll head- I mean a grey alien corpse that had been discarded from a human/alien hybrid cloning facility? I started to believe that the excitement was over for the night when I noticed something peculiar-

As he was driving my friend keep looking up into his rear view mirror every few seconds- he looked up into the rear view mirror then down at the road- then up at the mirror then

down at the road- his hands gripped the leather steering wheel cover tightly-

I could swear I could hear his grip eat into the shining steering wheel cover- I turned to look at the head lights behind us- there was a single car driving behind us on this dark windy road up in these mysterious east hills- the low rumble of his car and the wind whipping through my open window was the only thing I could hear-

The low rumble of his car grew higher and higher in pitch- he said nothing as he stared intensely down at the road- then up to the rear view mirror then back down at the road- over and over like a metronome as he tapped the side of the car with his free hand- the cars engine whining higher and higher as he went faster and faster-

I secured my grip on the door as I was sliding with each turn on this windy two lane road-

I looked back at the headlights behind us as they seemed to trail us perfectly staying at the same distance even though my friend was now speeding down this windy dark road- he broke the silence “ yep “ he said “ yep” he added “ what?” I asked- he jerked the wheel to the side to make a sharp turn to stay on the road- “ fuck” he shouted “ fuck fuck fuck fuck “ he repeated with each glance up to the mirror and down to the road “ fuck fuck fuck fuck “ he kept on “ yep yep shit “ he shouted with his eyes burning forward “ what is it?” I said as I looked at him and back at the car perplexed “ fuck, this guy is good “ he remarked as he sped down the road now at a dangerous speed which made me fear for our safety just a little bit “ isn’t it obvious? “ he asked “ this guys got us- he’s on us- we should have never fucking come up here man- shit “ his voice wavered with a fearful tone “ we should have never fucking come up here- fuck fuck fuck” he barked as he slammed the steering

wheel with his fists with each fuck " this is it man we're fucked- he's got us- shit" as fast and as reckless as he drove those headlights stayed right behind us like some unseen force was tying that car to ours-

We continued speeding down the road with the secret alien agent spy assassin car following us. My friend banged on the steering while " fuck fuck fuck " he said as we sped toward a busy intersection- we had made it out of the hills but now we were trapped at this intersection and oh shit- the alien assassin car had changed lanes and was going to pull up right next to us-

I looked over at my friend " fuck fuck fuck" he shouted as he pressed into himself hard back into his seat squinting- scrunching his face preparing to be shot and killed by the high tech laser weapon this assassin was surely going to take us out with- the car pulled up to us- nether of us looked- we inhaled- waiting to die- waiting- waiting- waiting-

A few seconds pass and I was still alive-or I thought I was still alive- so I ever so slowly began to turn my head to face- according to my friends behavior was sure to be a laser gun pointed straight at my dome from this assassin who was "good" as my race car driver scientist friend had told me-

He was good and he was fucking dangerous and I was about to die here at the base of these mysterious woods in front of all these other drivers who were sure to be human clones that were placed here just to lure us into this trap and make us feel comfortable so we would stop and not just drive through them all like we should of so that we could be alive today and not dead-

I turned and looked into the car of the ruthless good alien assassin with uncanny driving abilities- I stared at him then back at my friend who still had his eyes closed and face

scrunched waiting for death- his left eye slowly let some light in and opened- he saw my still attached non assassinated head so he peeked over my shoulder and looked towards the car and saw a normal guy in a normal car with a baby in a baby seat in it "oh" my friend said as the light turned green.

We drove home at the usual pace- neither of us spoke of the artifact or the car chase- He was my friend and even if he was paranoid it still made things fun to be around him-

WE MADE IT

One weekday after I had gotten home from working as an under the table construction laborer for a friend of mine's brother- a big burly german man who could carry a refrigerator around by himself and mock me and my little muscles when I weighed 235 pounds and spent 4 hours a day in Golds Gym- so he was a big ass dude.

One day I has just finished riding my bike home from work- I was all dirty and sweaty from crawling around underneath some house- one of those times you're so filthy you've earned a shower- you're not some obsessive fuck taking two showers a day to wash off imaginary dirt that you got from going to school and back- no- you could take a real shower wherein you could see dirt coming off your body and swirling down the drain- chalky brown dirt leaving your complexion- making your face a better place-

I finished putting my bike away when I heard a helicopter approaching and then people cheering- cheers of 10-20 men- yelling and screaming- woo-ing and yeah-ing- the loud celebratory madness that you only hear in Murica when a team of millionaires owned by a millionaire have beaten another team of millionaires owned by a millionaire to win more millions and a big ass trophy they hold up and woo and yeah-

I don't understand why regular people get in such a frenzy from these millionaires winning their little game of chase ball or throw ball or jump ball or what the fuck ever? Who cares if the millionaires threw the thing and hit the thing and jumped the thing more times then the other millionaires so that they get trophies and money- whats that got to do with me and my family? and my friends? Oh wait I have no friends here because I have no interest in team sports oops!

Anyway, so I heard the cheers and woo's and thought to myself Superbowl? no- World Series? No- Nba finals? No- Stanley cup? no- Wrestlemania? no- I could think of no Murican reason for this group of 10-20 men from woo-ing so much-

I was perplexed- I don't follow team sports so whenever I hear cheering I later find out about the millionaires vs millionaires ball jump throw game that the Murican's were so passionate about- I mean its great that they are so passionate about the things that really matter- like the ball jump run games by millionaires- before I learned that they only cheered for trivial things I would wonder- did they just abolish federal income tax?- have they cured cancer?- have they erased everyones debt? -solved homelessness in America?-given us all good free healthcare? -found a way to stop the police from killing anybody looking at them wrong? Nope- just some run jump ball stick hoop celebratory dance game- oh Murica you're so frivolous with the things that make you woo and cheer like it matters. On this day the cheers were coming from WTMC's front yard.

So yeah- there was no reason for these men to be cheering here in Murica at that time-then I noticed something strange- as the helicopter got closer their cheers got louder- it was if they were cheering and yelling at the Helicopter itself- but why would they do that? I could almost make out some "over here's" amongst the chaos of the screams and woo's- As the helicopter flew past the cheers and yells grew faint and faded away with the last whine of the helicopters whining tail rotor. I had to find out what was going on.

I walked out onto the sidewalk and over to my neighbors house- smoke rose from a barbecue pit- 12 pack boxes torn asunder lay on the ground- blunts were being passed amongst the 15-20 gangsta rappers cavorting in my friends front yard- all the local rapper legends in their own minds were there-

Killa G- gangsta B- killa gangsta C- mack scroll killa D- there was a whole fucking alphabet of made gangsta men and CEO's of their own record labels out there-

I knew these CEO's because when I worked for the local video company that made their music videos I would meet ten CEO's a day- this was during the dot com bubble in Silicon Valley so CEO was a term that they must have heard was synonymous with being important. Since they were weaned on the crap gangsta bullshit rap that grew out of NWA in the 80's they wanted to be super important CEO's as well as killers and pimps that would not trust a hoe.

So when I was working at the video place a group of them would come in and introduce themselves to me like "I'm Killa G CEO of killa G records" "I'm Gangsta B CEO of Gangsta B records" "I'm Killa Gangsta C CEO if Killa Gangsta Records" and so on- So I met a lot of important men in my time at that company that I'm sure are still big movers and shakers in the entertainment industry today.

I mean all they really did back then was produce shitty unoriginal music as an excuse to feel important and throw shows at clubs so they could put hot chicks in their videos and on guests lists in hopes of banging them in an attempt to achieve the gangsta triad- Money- Hoes- Tattoo's-

So I recognized Loco killa gangsta Boss R and whoever the fuck else was there. I must state that I wasn't a rapper at that time but I eventually became one years later and after rhyming cat and hat and gun and fun within 8 bars I had reached their level of skill- but what can you say- they didn't do the music for the music- the music was a means to an end to achieve Money- hoes- tattoo's and CEO business cards with chrome print.

They were all there celebrating I don't know what- but they were sure happy about something and it had something to do with helicopters- maybe they got too high and left the hose running in the front yard and though they were stranded on a desert island? As it was pretty hot that summer day in San Jose- So they're high and stranded and they think that helicopter is there to save them? Close, but the truth was much sadder than that-

A trend I've noticed with the local gangsta rappers- they are all so concerned with telling everyone and bragging about having "made it" and being in the "big time" when none of them have ever even come close to that- the neighborhood was a lower middle class neighborhood- none of them had anything really except the one rich kid from the rich family that lived up in the hills and just hung out with these dudes for a touch of street cred- you guys are poor so you validate the "struggle" I rap badly about in my shitty songs I made on $25,000 dollars worth of equipment that my family bought for me- Well anyway, Rich boy was there and not the famous Rich boy who dropped the master piece "throw some D's" on the world- who I'm sure now has a PhD from an ivy league school in philosophy as dude was straight lyricist artist philosopher wordsmith- yes-

So non PhD Rich Boy rich boy was there- everyone who was a CEO was there woo-ing- clanking 40's- passing blunts- something big had gone down in regard to domestic aircraft used by the police department and I needed to know what it was.

As I stood there watching the spectacle of so many CEO's from so many reputable companies doing business together my friend WTMC saw me and sauntered over after taking a hit of a blunt- he shook my hand and we did that half hug man thing " dude it happened " he said proudly " this is it- it

happened “ he said “ what happened” I asked “ I almost couldn’t believe it but you know we’ve been working at this for so long it finally happened “ he said looking back at the CEO’s who nodded their heads-

I had no idea what he was talking about “ we’re throwing this party as a celebration “ he said “ for what? what happened “ I asked- he picked up a 40 and took a swig “ well you know how I told you my boy Gangsta Killa Ace Scrilla P works at Wild 108.999 “ he said which was a guy and a radio station I sort of remembered at the time “ naw, I didn’t know he worked there “ I said “ well you know E-40 right? “ he asked “ yeah” I answered “ well you know that single I just finished “We made it, the big time gangsta pimp hoe kill you” “ he said about another gangsta song he had made that was indistinguishable from all the others he made “ yeah I remember that song “ I said as when I was fixing his computer we would listen to the songs he was working on-

I liked his beats and he had a good voice and decent rhyme skills but he always rapped about bullshit that had nothing to do with his real life- nothing that any of us could really relate too- just some gangsta fantasy life that nobody lived outside of the fictional character Tony Montana from the movie Scarface who died riddled with bullets and cocaine all over his face-

I don’t even know how people could view that character as an inspirational one to strive to be— because you figure you’re going to die anyway so you might as well go out big? I don’t get it- he was trying to build up some facade like the CEO’s in the front yard with their business cards- they all wanted to be corporate Tony Montana’s- they all wanted to be Jerry Heller- the guy that formed NWA and made all his money off of them and their dumb-ass lyrics and attitude that encouraged people to kill each other while he got paid- so even

at the highest level these studio gangsters were being pimped by corporate gangsters- so on the lowest levels like my friend and his CEO crew- the shit was just sad-

Sad, but not the saddest as you don't know why they were cheering for the helicopter- " yeah so my friend was at work in the radio station and he gave E-40 a copy of my song " WTMC continued with his story as I could still not see the helicopter connection- " So then E-40 listened to it and " he stopped talking as his eyes shot upward toward another police helicopter- I watched his eyes lock on to the helicopter with fire and intensity- the cracks in his skin shatter into a "yeaaaaah" his hoarse voice cried out and cracked, tired- as if he had been screaming all day- the CEO's erupted as well- cheering, wooing, waving at the helicopter.

WTMC waved his arms at the helicopter frantically trying to get its attention- the helicopter flew past without any hesitation and their cheers died down again " it must have had to refuel " WTMC said in a tired raspy tone as his gaze fired through the dirt and torn boxes of beer at his feet.

He rattled his 40 around reinvigorated with a heavy inhale- he focused his eyes back on me " So E-40 listened to my cd- to my song and he said it was tite " he said with wonder in his eyes " so yep were just out here waiting for them now- we made it dude! " he said as he put his hand on my shoulder- I was touched that he had chosen to include me on his team that helped him make it- I really did like him and considered him a friend but I still didn't see the connection to the helicopter-

He pumped his fist and fist bumped one of the CEO's " so yeh man any time now- we made it- its gonna happen " he said reassuring himself with a chorus of "yeah's" and "yups" behind him as the CEO's backed him up.

I had to ask now because I still wasn't any closer to understanding the situation- " so whats with the helicopter? How come you guys are yelling at it?" I asked- he smiled and put his hand over his mouth as if I had missed the obvious- " dude- E-40 is going to sign me to his label- they are going to send the helicopter for me so I can sign the contract- this is it- I made it " he spoke what he believed to be the truth and what I knew to be a sad lie to himself as he stood in the dirt in our lower class neighborhood with his yes men CEO friends behind him-

It probably only got this far because his boys that were supposed to back him up chose to back up a major delusion. Or maybe they wanted to believe it? Did they even care? Did they just want an excuse to drink and get high?

"Are you sure he said he was going to sign you and send a helicopter" I asked- trying to inject some doubt and reality into the situation " well dude he said he liked the song so I'm gonna get signed " he laughed- " but I mean just because he said he liked it doesn't mean he's going to sign you- let alone send a helicopter " I said in a soft voice-

He shook his head and looked up to the sky " dude all I know is that I made it " he said again as he turned away and went back amongst the CEO's. I stood there for a second and watched them revel and celebrate- they really seemed happy- I took my hand off of the wood picket fence I was leaning on and walked home. Just before I ducked inside I heard another police helicopter flying nearby with the swell of their cheers and woo's- he made it- if the helicopter doesn't stop and pick him up its because they have to refuel- he made it.

DARK SIDE YOUNG EYES

My dad loved San Francisco- he would talk about San Francisco of the past as if were still that way today- once, while he still lived with us when I was 5 or 6 years old he went to San Francisco alone- It was a Friday afternoon- my dad watched my sister and I during the day- my mom worked full time as a social worker to support us so she came home at her normal time but my dad was nowhere to be found- I just remember blurbs and flashes- numbers and phrases- dad emptied the family bank account and left us-

We went with our mother to the bank- dad had taken all the money out of their account- the money for food- for rent- all the money- somehow my mom knew that he had gone to San Francisco- maybe because he always talked about that place- that place from the past-

So that Friday we drove up to San Francisco- it was late Friday afternoon- at that point I liked San Francisco as it had tons of fun stuff for kids to do- thats all I had seen of San Francisco- Pier 39- the Exploratorium- Fishermans wharf- the things children and tourists see- the sanitized version of "the city"

My mom had worked as a social worker in San Francisco so she knew the town like the back of her hand- she knew all the flop houses- all the shitty motels filled with junkies and hookers- she knew every street in the tenderloin- over that weekend we visited every flophouse, we went in every shitty hotel and bar filled with junkies-

We walked every street in the tenderloin at night- screaming voices echoing from the flophouses above- an argument about who knows what- a woman screaming- broken

bottles, trash, needles, the smell of piss- this was the real city and I got to know every meter of it that weekend-

We searched all night Friday, all day and night Saturday, all day and night Sunday- it all turned into a haze in my mind- a blur of blinking titty lights, laughing crowds with bottles in hand, the smell of trash and salt water- I woke up in the car Sunday and saw a strange man in a black coat with a scraggly beard sitting outside- it was a hotdog stand- the glow from the neon lights warmed the inside of the car-

I felt as if I was in another world just waking up seeing that strange man who was my father- she had found him that night- somewhere, in some hotel and she brought him home with us- I learned that when my dad drank and smoke he turned into a bad man- and that weekend he was drinking and smoking- he stunk like the beer cans we picked up at the beach to fill plastic trash bags on the weekends for extra money and like the cigarettes I tried to smoke with my friend in his mom's closet a few weeks before- gross.

He had a light beard and was talking faster than usual- he was more aggressive than usual- When he drank alcohol and smoked he was a bad man I learned- he only had about a hundred bucks left I learned- when we got home I became the police- alcohol and smoking bad- San Francisco bad- my mom made him take a shower- I searched his room- I found a pack of cigarettes and a half empty bottle of thunderbird- I gave it to my mom- I've hated San Francisco ever since.

After my father died in 2014 I learned more about his upbringing- he never knew his real father- his stepfather hated him and abused him- he sent him to a boarding school at age 3- he joined the navy at age 18- he sustained a head injury in the service and was in and out of the veterans hospitals ever since-

I've come to believe that men without fathers can have a hard time being fathers themselves- they can have a hard time relating to other men- to boys- I didn't have a difficult time relating to other men as I had become a creative machine that collected data and mined experiences to create- and at this specific point in time I was going to mine this homeless man's horrible secret for an animation- for an animation about pay toilets and strange predatory creatures that come out when no one is looking- except for their unknowing victims of course.

Before going forward with this man let me say something about fathers.

When I was in Paris having dinner with the very nice and generous artist that showed me around the city after he saw me talk about my animated film at a conference there-

He urged me to have children- he told me "right now you are a son- when you have a child you are no longer a son- you become a father- it is a great change" I understood the point he was making and I would generally agree except that I have never been a son-

I have, and will never be a father but I have never been a son.

I never felt sorry for myself for not having a father to teach me things and take me places- I just did it myself-

From ages 11-17 I was obsessed with baseball- I practiced and played every day even though I had no one to play or practice with- baseball is a team sport so I played on some teams and enjoyed that part of it- most of the boys were brought to practice by their fathers- The position I wanted to play was pitcher- but I had no father- I had no dad to play catch with- I didn't even think about it at the time- I just came up with ideas

to work around the limitation of wanting to practice baseball with no one to practice with-

As a small child I remember standing in the schoolyard perplexed as the other boys argued with each other about whose dad could beat up whose dad " my dad does karate he'll beat up your dad " one boy would say " my dad has a motorcycle he'll beat up your dad " another would reply-

I never participated in these dad vs. dad arguments as I never felt like I needed to act like a warmongering politician on behalf of the all powerful state of my dad- fast forward to adulthood and I came to realize that many men with active and present fathers come to rely on them for advice- what car to buy- how to fix something- when to get married- they became dependent on them- I never had that dad to depend on so I didn't cry or complain- I didn't even think about it- if there was something I wanted to do I'd figure out how to do it on my own- I wanted to do it so I'd find a way how- I wanted to play catch but there was no dad to play with- so what- find a way-

For playing catch I asked my mom to buy me several pitch backs- these were devices made of mesh and springs that would bounce a baseball back to you if you threw one at it- I broke all of them from throwing the ball too hard- So I built my own pinchbeck type device out of rope and chicken wire-

I strung a heavy rope across two trees then hung several layers of chickenwire over the rope- the chicken wire hung to the ground and sort of curled towards it so that when I through a ball at it- the layers of chicken wire would deaden the ball then the curve would cause it to roll down the chicken wire and roll back towards me- I spent hours and hours every day throwing the ball into it-

In one of my baseball leagues there was a really good pitcher whose dad was always at the games cheering him on- I heard that his dad made him throw 100 pitches every day and thats why he was so good- from throwing into my pitch back I had built up a lot of arm strength but I had no control at all- I was a “wild” pitcher- so I would then walk over to a nearby schoolyard and tape a square over the cyclone fencing on the backstop and throw into that for hours by myself trying to work on my control-

I didn’t know what I was doing as I had no coaching at the time- to practice hitting I had no one to pitch balls to me like I saw dad’s doing in the movies so I would walk to one side of the field throw the ball up to myself- hit it- retrieve it then hit it again to the other side of the field and keep doing that for hours by myself-

No supervision- repetition- alone- this became a pattern in my life which eventually lead me into getting my first feature film that I animated alone into the biggest film festival in the world and beat studio films with multimillion dollar budgets out of awards, getting chased by top talent agencies in Hollywood while being offered deals by major film studios-

I’ll tell those stories in another book but long story short- I ignored them all because Hollywood is a rotten place full of greedy douchebags and horrible people.

I’d already met enough douchebags in my life and I didn’t want to be contractually obligated to any of them at that time. TOUGH BOYS y QUE?!

THE TOE MONSTER

Just an average day in the neighborhood-

The sound- a cross between a velociraptor growl and a fighter jet screeching through the neighborhood- uneven footsteps echoing up and down the street as he searched for a new victim- all the kids run and hide- for he was here- this strange squealing crooked man that walked with a limp- trying not to make a sound lest he heard you- waiting for him to continue on chasing some other unfortunate children-

At first kids would be entertained by this strange adult named Gabbie- his shaggy beard and thick glasses- the drool glistening in the corner of his mouth- “ha ha ha ha ha” he’d laugh out as they smiled in shock and awe at this human sideshow of a mid twenties man- but I knew Gabbie’s game -so I would hide and just hope he didn’t hear me-

I was about six at the time when this man starting showing up- terrorizing the children- who was he? what did he want? Where did he come from?

He wanted your feet.

“Let meeeee seeeee your tooooooes“ he’d squeal as he adjusted something inside his pants “hahahhaaaa let me see your tooooooes“ he’d shout excitedly as some new kid would hold their foot up with a puzzled look on their face- why did this weird squealing man get so excited by feet?

We didn’t get it back then- we just came to know that it was weird- and we had to hide from him-

As you played with your friends outside you were always on edge- for if you heard the sound of his uneven

shuffling across the pavement and his velociraptor scream it was time to hide or he would get your feet- “ let meeeeee seeeee your tooooooooes “ I’ll never the forget that sound- or the look on his face as it contorted with pleasure as he looked at and often touched the feet of neighborhood children “ hahhaahaaaa “ he’d laugh.

Years later when I was in high school- Gabbie showed up at school- one of the teachers told me that he had been a regularl kid in that very school years before- but in his Senior year he was drunk driving and got severe brain damage from a car accident-

He went from being Johnny football to a creepy dinosaur with a foot fetish rubbing his junk on innocents kids feet. I don’t think he specifically had a thing for kids- they were probably just the only people that would humor him sometimes- not understanding his possible- nefarious intentions-

NO HELMET HARD BALL

My friends and I were often found playing baseball on a local diamond when we were 11-14 years old- we met lots of interesting people there-

Once this drunk or high on pcp older guy in his 40's asked to pitch to one of us- we were playing hard ball with no helmets- but we were playing "lob ball" where you just lobbed it- you never threw it hard as we knew how it felt to get hit by a hard ball when it came at you fast-

So this random adult man shows up babbling something about being Vida Blue who was a famous local pro baseball player from twenty years in the past- " I'm Vida Blue " he mumbled as he asked for the baseball.

He was not Vida Blue- but hey we were just some boys on the baseball field-so this man must know what he was doing- a kid stepped up to the plate- this man wound up and threw the ball as hard he could- and it hit this kid square in the middle of the back with a THUD-

The kid fell to the ground- crying- twisting and rolling in pain as you do when you're hit with a baseball thrown by an adult as hard as they can muster- he was reaching to the middle of his back gasping for air-

The man mumbled "I'm Vida Blue" then walked off the field and toward a nearby liquor store- we tended to the kid and never let any strange adult men pitch to us again-

An adult man played football with us once- he was probably in his thirties- we were 13 or 14- he was playing super hard- like really trying to hurt us- Bobby, our alpha male leader asked him to settle down- the guy said something like "yeah

yeah" then tackled another kid really hard- the kid still on the ground crying- I don't remember exactly what happened- I sort of remember the guy acting like he was going to fight Bobby- then he backed down and left- we didn't have dad's but Bobby was the closest thing to it-

Out on that crappy baseball field we never had many kids to play with- so the only "games" we had were two on two games of "pitchers hand" baseball- where one kid was a pitcher and another kid the single fielder- making up a two person team- when the batter hit the ball they had to make it to first base before the fielder got the ball back in the pitchers hand or the batter was out- it was not an easy way to play baseball- and if the batters were really good innings could go on forever as the pitchers were just lobbing the ball so that it was easy to hit-

Some times we would get all macho and play fast pitch with hard balls- with no helmets- kids would get hit- they would claim not to cry- the others would make fun of them for crying- they would deny crying- then slink off to some corner of the field so they could cry and feel shame for crying in peace- thats how you made these tough boys- it was if crying was the worst thing a boy could do " I wasn't crying! I didn't cry " kids would yell- I don't remember if I cried for something like that once I had become a tough boy-

I cried like a baby when my first girlfriend dumped me though- where was my tough boy then? Little bastard abandoned me?! Come back tough boy!

MULLET MAN IS FINE BRO

We had lots of two on two baseball battles on that field- Bobby and I were an undefeated team- we had played tons of kids and never lost a game- ever- it was one of the few things we had to feel proud of back then- that and great invention fart juice of course-

So one day we were out there throwing the ball around as there were two fat men sitting on the benches by the right field fence " ay " one of them yelled at us with a tough sounding voice " want to play us? " the tough voice asked- Bobby and I looked at each other "Sure- were up first though" Bobby yelled back as the two fat men got up and walked towards us-

This was our trick- we would always want to be up first and never make any outs- never giving the other team a chance to bat- this destroyed their morale and they would always quit from getting tired chasing the balls around- making us the winners-

There were unlimited innings in pitchers hand on that field- so whoever had the resolve to keep playing longer than the other team would always win- or if the other kids had to be home earlier than you did you could beat them like that too-

As these two big men got closer we were surprised to see that they were not men- but were in fact two butch lesbians with flat tops- "we're up first" I said as I stood at the plate at bat- they slowly put the gloves on- one went to the patch of dirt we used as a pitchers mound and the other went to the outfield-

Most of the games Bobby and I played went like this- we'd be up first- we'd hit the ball all over the park- making the opponents so tired from running after the ball and frustrated and

because we never made any outs they would forfeit- quit- and this game was no different- we smacked the ball everywhere as they huffed and puffed- eventually quitting and walking off as slow as they walked up-

Hardball was a dangerous sport but the worst sports ball related injury took place in a softball game- I was 15 playing softball at a friends family picnic- I was a runner on third base- as a short fat man with a mullet was at bat- he hit a ground ball right in front me to the third baseman- it was too close for me to advance home so I watched the short fat mullet man sprint to first base as the third baseman fired a laser right into the short fat mullet mans head-

BLAP- it hit him square in the side of the head- he dropped to the ground and tumbled a bit before popping back up with an “I’m ok” like macho men often do- I was a sick teenager with a twisted sense of humor so I thought it looked funny how he fell then pretended he wasn’t hurt even though he clearly was- standing on rubbery legs-

He insisted on staying in the game- acting like a tough man with a mullet even though his wife was on the side of the field pleading with him to stop as she could see he was clearly hurt- mullet man stayed in game bro- he was a gamer bro- the inning ended and we went out to play the field-

I was in center field- the mullet man was playing second base- shortly after the inning started I noticed a dark stain of the back of his loose fitting softball pants- he had crapped his pants- I was sick fuck- so I thought it was funny- laughing as I replayed the ball hitting him in the head in my mind watching him in crappy pants field ground balls like everything was fine-

I almost missed a fly ball that came my way because I was giggling so hard to myself like I had a mental problems.

The left fielder looked over me as I laughed like I had got hit in the head- I kept my composure after that- one of the other men noticed that he had crapped his pants which can happen when someone gets concussed-

I knew that then and I guess I thought it was funny because he was acting so macho about it like " I'm fine bro " when its like " bro you just crapped your pants bro " he just wouldn't quit and the mullet just made it worse- some of the other men got him to sit out of the game- the game ended and the last time I saw him he was sitting on a curb vomiting with crapped pants and a mullet- his wife standing over him patting his back shaking her head as if saying " I tried to warn you mullet man and look what you've done pukin and a crappin your self- but mullet man- your mullet has remained to stand strong so in the end you are a real man "

Years later I still laugh to myself at the image of that macho mulleted man a crappin and a pukin- the ball bouncing off his head replayed over and over " I'm fine bro- I'm fine- lets play ball bro "

He was so much of a macho man he just couldn't call it a day- I mean when do you call it a day? After you sustain a concussion and can barely stand up? Nah I'll be fine bro just have to catch my breath-

Do you call it a day when you shit your white softball pants in public- and shit them so much the center fielder can see them from 100 feet away? Nah bro I meant to shit my pants- I do that to scare bears away when I'm out hunting- not that I'm scared of a bear or anything bro I'll snap its neck bro-

Do you call it a day when you start puking all over yourself in a parking lot pants already shat with wobbly legs? Hey where's everybody going bro? I'm ready to go another nine innings bro- just getting rid of this excess half digested food bro- its slowing me down bro- I'm like a jet getting rid of excess fuel bro- Buaaaaahhhhh!

That day I learned softball could be a dangerous sport- to the male ego-

KEGGAR HEAD FOUNTAIN

Sometimes as pre-teens we went to the girls and boys club a few blocks away- we didn't really like the adults who worked there so we didn't go very often- we met some interesting kids there- a fat kid that everyone called "Kegger" who cheated on a race we had there once- the race was 4 laps around this little field- I was in the lead on the fourth lap- I was the only kid that was really trying- So I was going to win by default because I tried-

I was keeping track of everyone else and I knew Kegger was only on his second lap yet as he finished his second lap just before I finished my last " I won! " he said- lying to the staff who didn't pay attention giving him the little trophy for winning the event at that years "boys and girls club olympics"

I was pissed in second place- years later I heard he "got stabbed in the top of the head" in a gang fight and "blood was shooting out the top of his head like fountain" that's exactly how I heard it- "muthafucker shouldn't have cheated in that race" 16 year old me thought upon hearing the news- he didn't die and I hope that stopped Kegger's cheatin gang bangin ways- and give me my little meaningless trophy fool!

There was a major controversy at that boys and girls club the next year as the morbidly obese man named "Junior" who ran the wood shop there and also drove a "Ninja" motorcycle that made him instantly cool with a lot of the boys even though it looked fucking ridiculous as his organic saddlebacks of fat hung over the sides of the severely slammed bike when he rode it- he was arrested for both selling drugs to kids out of the club as well as molesting female members- but he had a Ninja- cool guy-

The men who ran the club treated it as sort of their own ultimate fighting championship- whenever two boys got into a fight or even into an argument- one of the adult stuff would run up and say “put the gloves on” and lead the boys over to the cement basketball court- and seemingly out of nowhere two pairs of boxing gloves would show up in the hands of the staff-

I just remembering hearing several people repeating “put the gloves on” - “then put the gloves on” everyone sort of knew how this went- the staff would put the boxing gloves on the two boys and make them fight in front of everyone right there and now- the kids would be jawing back and forth “ imma fuck you up bitch” and the like they would say- they would fight and someone would end up crying or get hurt- then the staff would make them shake hands-

GUERO: THE DOG PUNK

Bobby was standing at my doorstep with blood trickling down his leg- “fucking Guero bit me” he said dumbfounded “that fucking punk dog“ he added “Ha ha Guero bit you too” I laughed- so, he bit you first!” he answered- as the dog had bitten me a few days before this 14th year of our lives.

Yes- Guero had bit me as well- but unlike what happened with Bobby’s not so tough leg- my super tough leg didn’t even bleed blood- I now had an opportunity to out tough Bobby-

I stepped back- tilted my head up and with the smuggest look I could muster as I said “yeah, Guero bit me- but” as I paused for drama and finished with “he didn’t draw blood”

I had my mic drop tough boy moment- Bobby’s leg bled and mine didn’t- my leg had won ten tough boy points I could cash in with Rambo or Chuck Norries at some point later in life I assumed for free hot chicks or a motorcycle or something?

Bobby stared at me in shock- it was checkmate- the fluffy white punk dog had bitten both of us but he had drawn Bobby’s blood which meant that my leg was somehow tougher than his using this crude- tough boy logic-

I stood there looking smug- enjoying one of the few psychological tough man battles that I had won against Bobby.

At this point the neighborhood punk dog which was named “Guero” had bitten everybody I knew-

This fucking punk dog had gotten all of us on the leg- some of us were on foot- some of us were on bikes- you'd know it wanted to bite you and you'd kick at it but this little punk dog found a way to bite you- at first you would laugh thinking it couldn't get you- then it did- this dog was a punk-

It wasn't a very big dog so it didn't seem threatening- it was just a punk and it drew blood-

So we had all gotten bitten by the dog- someone had called animal control a few times but the owners never did anything- it just stayed outside the front of their house all day chasing and biting people-

It also pimped the many cats that family owned- we laughed as it often humped the cats heads- weird fuckin dog- who knows that that dog was into- head humpin?!

We noticed its pimping ways as it would sort of wrangle two of three cats under a parked car- hump each ones head- and if any other dogs or cats approached it would bark and chase them away- returned to hump some more cat heads- weird fucking dog with its cat head harem-

As the dog pimped cats and chased and bit people- we became his captive audience- I'm sure he would have had his own successful reality show and associated clothing line and scent today- a whole brand- cat head humpin pimp assault force dog, dog-

We watched this dog every day- we decided to celebrate him instead of being angry- we'd appreciate the comedy that this dog could create- so we would hide in a nearby tree all day watching the dog chase and bite other people like it bit us- it weighed maybe ten or fifteen pounds so it couldn't kill

anyone- it was just a punk- it bit you just because it could- then it had this smug look on his stupid pimp dog face-

We'd giggle while sitting in this little plum tree in the front of and above the dogs biting patrol zone- we'd have to run from him to get up there in the first place- once we got up there he didn't bark or anything- he just left us alone so we could enjoy his punk dog show-

We watched it bite the mailman- the guy that read the gas meters- he tried to use the tennis ball on a stick he was given to defend himself against 200 pound pitbull's but this dog didn't care- this dog didn't give a shit- it ignored the stupid ball on a stick and bit the guys bare fucking leg just like it bit our legs- then it went over and humped some cat head- thug life-

The dog was white- so of course the owners named it "Guero" which is Spanish for what else- white. They also had a black dog- and guess what its name was? "Negro" which means black.

It bit parents walking their kids to school- they'd run and panic and fall down and the dog would attack their purses or backpacks- their kids would cry and they'd run away from this white menace- it was a small white dog with a big fluffy tail- a straight up punk-

It would bite you just to do it- it was as if it knew it wasn't really hurting you bad and it did it just to piss you off- one of my friends it bit tried to play his injury up limping around with thick bandages as he threatened the dickhead owners that he was going to sue them- the owners were the asshole guy that had the illegal slaves in his backyard- they laughed at my friend who was trying to lawyer up on their front porch as the dog attacked him again- this time on the other leg- he hobbled and screamed as he limped down the street-

He fancied himself a basketball player even though he wasn't that good and was trying to take an angle like "your dog damaged my precious future pro basketball player legs" the asshole owners were only semi literate but they knew he was full of shit so they told the dog to attack him "Get him! Guero!" they said while laughing as the dog chased him down the street. He quit faking his injury and ran away at full speed.

That guy was always mentioning how tall he was like he would say "I almost hit my head because I'm so tall" or "well you know being as tall as I am" then he would go into some useless story so we would say "yeh dude we know you are the tallest man in the world"

He would walk by us and palm our heads like he was some giant and we were two feet tall when in reality he was just slightly taller than us-

PEPSI AND CIGARETTES

It was extra funny to see this pompous ass get bit by the punk dog- that poor guy though had a mom that was like some mythical creature that just scowled at him and forced him to go on endless quests for Pepsi and cigarettes- and it didn't even give him gold or anything- just some extra change that could by a licorice rope or a pickle maybe-

The same frozen pouting baby scowl on her face with tattooed eyebrows- a tank top that was too small and daisy dukes- which were cut off jean shorts as small as they could be-

I know it may seem messed up to go so hard on this woman who was my friends mom- but my mom worked full time- put herself through school- raised my sister and I on her own and was really nice to us and our friends- supporting us on her own-

This woman never worked ever- she had no education- just sat around at home watching TV in daisy dukes bitchin at her kids with that scowl on her face and was unfriendly to all of his friends-

I only ever heard her say five words "gimmie cigarettes and a Pepsi" or different combination of those words in the angry phrases she spoke that always seemed to contain Pepsi and cigarettes.

She would yell at him with these five words to send him off to the corner liquor store what seemed twenty times a day to get her a pack of Marlboro cigarettes and a two liter of Pepsi-

He'd bring it back and I shit you not- she'd rip open the Pepsi start and gulping it down saying " mmmm Pepsi" then tear open the cigarettes-light one and take a deep inhale saying "mmm cigarettes" then she'd have more pepsi " mmm Pepsi" a puff " cigarettes" it was a joyous occasion for her and she'd repeat this fifty times a day but it was really fucking weird to see this Pepsi and cigarettes creature do its thing-

Looking back she must have been on welfare or something to have all that cigarette and Pepsi money- all my friends and families were poor pretty much-

My mom worked full time as a licensed social worker but we still didn't have enough money.

She was too proud to get on any type of assistance so instead we'd go to the nearby beach Saturday and Sunday morning to pick up bottles and cans to recycle-

We'd also buy most of our clothes and toys from "The Segunda" or second hand store. The second hand stores were fun because you never knew what you might find but I never liked picking up cans.

I still remember the smell of a can of warm rotten Coors dripping out of a sandy beer can on the beach- on a cold grey morning when you wanted to be at home watching cartoons- that smell was gross-

When ever I went to the tall guys house- I'd stand there in a daze at the Pepsi and cigarettes monster that lurked inside of there- it never worked and it never went to school- it didn't do anything except consume Pepsi and cigarettes-

The punk dog had bit her proud tallest man in the world cigarette and Pepsi courier boy- but she didn't give a shit cause she still had mmmm Pepsi and mmmm cigarettes-

So the dog kept biting people for a week or so- until animal control picked it up for the last time and it never came back- and of course the asshole owners blamed animal control for the dogs death- not themselves for letting it run loose biting everyone-

ENTER PACO: REIGN OF BLOOD

I wanted to tell the story of the worst thing I'd ever seen related to balls-

I was 9 or 10 years old and a new kid had moved in next door- it was a kid that ended up being one of my best friends named Paco- he was a few years younger than us- this kid was a badass- he showed up on the block riding a gas powered dirt bike- we had never even seen a dirt bike and this kid was jumping curbs in one- as we watched he leapt over the fence into my yard and started climbing a tree- we stood there looking at each other in an awkward silence as kids often do when they first meet-

It was me and Bobby watching this kid climb a tree- we didn't react so he started getting reckless- he was jumping from branch to branch- we simply stood and watched him- he jumped around the tree a bit frustrated by our lack of a reaction- so then he went for it- he flipped upside down and hung on a brach with his legs- we'd never seen that before but we still just stood there as we didn't know what to do besides watch- so we just watched-

As he tried to flip back onto his feet- his feet had missed the branch and he fell about 15 feet out of the tree and onto a low hanging branch- with his balls- he screamed out in pain as we laughed- he kept crying " ahhhhhh ohhhh ahhhhh" we couldn't breath- " ohhhh don't laugh guys I'm hurt- really bad" we laughed harder at this mortally wounded seven year old " don't laugh ahhhhh I broke my balls " he groaned- broke his balls?

We laughed even harder- we were literally rolling on the ground- he groaned louder as he pulled his pants and

underwear down “uuuuahhhhhh” he groaned- his red and purple junk screaming in pain right there in front of us “ he broke his balls” we laughed- we couldn’t catch our breaths as he yelled out “ ooooahhhhhh “ and began to urinate blood right there in front of us- talk about first impressions!

The purple blood spurted out of his angry penis as he groaned “ooouuuaaaaahhhh it hurts “ This kid was the funniest kid we had ever seen ever-

“uuooaaaahhh look guys bloooood uuaaaaahhhh” he groaned- but we just couldn’t stop laughing- that was how I got to know one of my best childhood friends- he ended up not sustaining any long lasting injuries from his fall and subsequent ball busting- he was a true ball breaker though as our sides were killing us-

GAS STATION RIOT MAKER

After school special- when I did start going to high school again I would often stop by my friend Bobby's house- he lived on a corner directly across the street from a gas station- we had messed with the gas station before changing the gas prices on the metal flip signs to five cents- laughing while watching it get swarmed with cars- the yelling and the anger was great- but Bobby had discovered the best thing to do with the gas station-

After 5pm the gas station would be packed with people getting gas after work- if you looked at the gas station from Bobby's front door- which was one of these heavy black screen doors you couldn't see through- you could see two rows of gas pumps- behind the pumps was a large cement wall which Bobby learned that sounds bounced off of-

"Watch this" Bobby said as two men stood with their heads down across from each other at the gas station pumping gas " fuck you- you faggot!" Bobby said in a fake manly voice- both men's heads shot up as they looked around startled- who had verbally attacked them and questioned their heterosexuality?!

If you looked at Bobby's house- it looked liked the front door was closed because of the black screen door you couldn't see through even though there was really two punk kids standing there smiling- the men looked around for a bit then went back to pumping gas " that's right I said it bitch " Bobby yelled- the sound of his voice bouncing off the cement wall and into the men's ears making them think the voice came from the other side- the side the other guy pumping the gas was on-

Both men's heads shot up again- this time they looked at each other- their voices rumbling- getting a bit louder as their heads started to snap back arguing- one of the men jumped in his

car and sped off- the other slamming the cap back on his gas tank “ thats right run away faggot “ Bobby said in his fake man voice- the man turned and faced the attendant that sat inside the small shop wherein you could pay for your gas or buy pork rind’s and orange soda- he grabbed his keys and stomped over- gesticulating wildly at the attendant then walking back to his car with fire in his eyes “ thats right run away bitch “ Bobby added as the man slammed his car door and sped away-

You could do that for hours and never get bored- at that point I thought he was so lucky to live across the street from a gas station with a magic screen door like that-

GRACE CHANG

Two twelve your olds sitting around bored- the phone rings and Bobby picks it up " No! There's no Grace Chang here- wrong number" Bobby says hanging up the phone annoyed " Who was that?" I asked- " These people always call here asking for Grace Chang- its a wrong number or something " he answered " huh thats weird " I said-

A few hours later we're still sitting there playing video games when the phone rings " No! There's no Grace Chang here " Bobby says annoyed " these fucking people " he adds- it was kinda funny to see him get so angry because of those phone calls-

That's when I got an idea " Hey maybe we should call people and say Grace Chang?" I said " yeh you think so" Bobby said " Yeah lets see what happens " I said as he reached for the white pages- we flipped through the pages looking for a victim- back then phone books were published and distributed with peoples home phone numbers listed in them with their full names-

We picked a number- Bobby dialed it as we both listened in on the phone " hello " a cheerful woman's voice said " Grace Chang" Bobby said as we giggled to ourselves " Excuse me? " the voice said " Grace Chang " Bobby repeated " There's no Grace Chang here " the voice said changing in tone " Grace Chang " Bobby said " There's no fucking Grace Chang here! " the voice screamed said as it hung up the phone- we laughed and laughed and decided that this was a great thing to do-

So we called people and just said "Grace Chang" over and over and that was fun for awhile- we started using his answering machine to record the calls so we could re-listen to them and share them with our friends- we started to try different

tactics- instead of saying “Grace Chang”- we would ask for random people like one night we decided to call random people and ask for “the fat ass” they would answer and we would say “ go get the fat ass “ we got into arguments- shouting and insults flew which we thought was great fun-

Then on one call a girl answered and I said “ go get the fat ass “ and she quickly replied “ Ricardo? “ surprised I just said “ go get the fat ass “ again to which she replied “ ok, hold on “ a kid that sounded around our age answered “ hello who is this? “ Ricardo said “ whats up fat ass? “ I said- we talked for about 15 minutes as he thought I was one of his friends- the call ended with screaming and insults like they usually did-

The best responses to these crank calls were the people that got really angry and started yelling and cursing- it was especially great when it was really old people that started yelling and cursing- Bobby and I would take turns on calls as we would try to outdo each other to see who could get the best and craziest response-

Our favorite thing to do was to call business- like call cutlery shops with this wimpy voice and tell them how dangerous knives were and that they should stop selling them “its really dangerous you should stoooop you really should stoooooop“ We just generally being annoying or irritating- we really enjoyed making adults angry-

Or calling the singing telegram/entertainer services and use the same lame guy voice and be like “ can you like send out a fat guy that could like sing me a song and then like do a dance all fat and can he have a weird hat- oh can he bring ice cream “ and just go on and on until they got pissed off and hung up-

We were such little bastards- we made so many people so angry- screaming into their phones- raging- I can still hear

some echoing through my mind- I think at one point we would ask for “John Holmes” the famous 70’s porn star we had heard about from one of Bobby’s friends that was an early bloomer when it came to his education in pornography.

We made one woman so angry she screamed at the top of her lungs “ No, there’s no John Holmes here you son of a bitch “ we had that one recorded and listened to it over and over-

We had made so many calls we started making our own compilation tapes that we handed out at school as people liked listening to them- some times friends would call me on a three way call to have me call their friends and troll them on the phone while they listened-

These were our Friday and Saturday nights for a long time- we’d make crank calls all night-

FIGURE FOUR LEG LOCK

We were really into this idea of “toughness” that we tried to get other kids we perceived as weak to “toughen up”

If we were wrestling or play fighting doing the things that ten years boys do and a kid started crying we’d stop and tell them to “be tough” if they kept crying it would frustrate us-

This lack of toughness would anger and disgust us so we’d punch them or put them in some pro wrestling move we saw on TV- if they kept crying we’d keep launching the pro wrestling moves at them until they stopped crying or went home.

Bobby was the master ten year old pro wrestler as he knew how to do finishing moves like the figure-four- a very painful leg lock that we had seen pro wrestlers use to finish matches- it was used in fake pro wrestling but the move really fucking hurt and Bobby used it on kids or anyone he could slap it on as often as possible-

I remember being at the park playing catch- looking over to see Bobby talking to some kid- I continued to play catch then I looked over a few minutes later- now Bobby had this kid in a figure-four- the kid was screaming as Bobby grabbed on to a nearby railing to make the move more painful- pro wrestlers would grab onto the ropes when the ref wasn’t looking to do this but in our neighborhood there was no ref’s- there were no adults- so rogue pro wrestler kids like Bobby ruled-

I laughed and kept playing catch- I looked over again a few minutes later and the kid had crawled underneath a filthy doormat and underneath a stairwell to try to escape the deadly figure four to no avail- now, I had to see this- I ran over to get a

closer look- there's Bobby yelling "Figure Four Figure Four!" as you often yelled out the pro wrestling move you were doing " DDT!" " Pile-driver!" - " Figure Four" could often be heard being screamed out by ten year olds from our backyards and bedrooms-

We knew this kid as "Woodsy" as he was chunky and looked like this cartoon owl that was on TV. He was still in the figure four but he had crawled all the way under this stairwell so you couldn't see him at all- you just saw Bobby yelling "Figure Four" with his legs stuck underneath this random stairwell-

Woodsy kept crying so Bobby released the move- we laughed as Woodsy crawled out then limped away from under the stairwell with dust and crap all over him.

FIGHT TO THE DEATH

When you're a bored kid with no after school activities you find ways of entertaining yourself and occupying time. As we were standing around in a friends backyard or apartment we'd hear the familiar shots and screams of the local "bums"

That's what people called them- it seemed like all of them were men and they were always drunk and/or angry. They become one of our favorite reality shows before reality shows were invented-

They yell at each other- threatened each other with slurred words and softly clenched fists- some times they would pull hair and wrestle on the floor- these guys were entertaining.

We didn't know any of their names so we gave them our own- we weren't very creative with their naming- we were probably inspired by the random bad guys in the stupid action movies we watched- or maybe we got the idea for their names by the random bad guys in a game like Final Fight.

There was Bum number 1, Bum number 2, Bum number 3, Bum number 2's girlfriend, Bum number 4 and Gibby. I think Gibby had an actual name because Bobby asked him to buy him beer before of something-

Anyway- these would be our conversations about them- " Dude, last night Bum number one was getting crazy- he was yelling at Bum number 2 then Gibby came and yelled at all of them and left with Bum Number two's girlfriend "

We met this other kid from the neighborhood that seemed crazier than us- he knew these Bum guys too but he had different names for them- he called Bum number one “Indian Bum” and he called Bum number one’s girlfriend “Indian bums girlfriend” as apparently he had stolen her from Bum number two- thats probably what all the commotion was about-

This kid was always trying to get them to do crazy stuff for money- this was like 10 years before the horrible “Bum Fights” website was around-

We were outside of the neighborhood library- the “bums” were out there laying on the ground- rolling around with big beers in paper bags when this kid went up to the man we knew as Bum Number one- he was like “Hey Indian bum I’ll give you fifteen bucks if you fight your friend to the death” - “Too the death?” the faded man said. “Yeah fight him and beat him and I’ll give you this money” said the kid as he waved the money around.

Both bum men looked at the money and excuse the pun- bum rushed each other- they starting punching in slow motion- kicking- pulling hair- moaning while they rolled around on the sidewalk in front of the libraries bike racks- the kid was dying- I was more in shock as I hadn’t seen adults fight like this before in person-

It was nothing like the movies or pro wrestling- it was sloppy and painful to watch- after a little while Bum number one stood up as the victor and asked for the money- the just laughed and ran away without giving him any money-

I stood there for a few seconds looking at this dejected, sickly, sunburned sweaty man before riding away on my bike.

TERROR ROOM

I can hear my own gasps for air as I jog through a dark humid tunnel- muffled music thumps through the floor- I reach out for the greasy carpeted walls and grasp a human shoulder- I pull my hand back and lurch through the darkness trying to find a way out of this dank maze- scented with urine and spilled soft drinks-

A strobe light fires throwing me into bullet time as strange children's faces flip past mine frame by frame- some caught mid laughter- other mid cry- others just blank-

I see a light up ahead and inhale the cool fresh air with a smile on my face- I pass through the tunnel- blinded by the shining blinking lights blasting the stage above the tunnel I have just emerged from-

Strange animatronic creatures jerk back and forth with fake guitars in their oversized plush paws- their jaws moving up and down like pistons far off from the words they are supposed to be singing- I look out at the room- tables clothes stained with orange oil from hard flat slices of cheese pizza- large plastic pitchers of soft drinks melt on every table under the hot lights of the stage-

I look back towards the dark tunnel underneath the stage filled with pantomiming animatronic performers and run back inside to repeat the same uncomfortable- sometimes terrifying struggle through the dark claustrophobic urine soaked passage again-

For some reason it seemed like the right thing to do- Why? It was horrible but you went back in and so did many other children you would meet in that tunnel- meeting- as in bumping into- accidentally grabbing on to- some were

screaming- some were crying- you couldn't really tell what was going on in there-

I wonder if anyone really knew or if they just cleaned up the mess a few times a week inside of "Mr. Munch's Mad House" thats what it was officially called- but back then it was just a hole in the wall to crawl into that smelled bad and was scary.

In recent years a video game called "Five Nights at Freddie's" has become a huge hit- that game is based on an American theme restaurant called "Chuck E. Cheese" specifically as it relates to the true story of some murders that took place inside one of the restaurants. Chuck E. Cheese was the restaurant I was in- running through those dark tunnels while the animatronic characters performed on stage.

I did too many things as a child that I didn't question-

If other kids were doing them I assumed it was ok so I did them too- other kids were running into that tunnel so I did too- it was a brief nightmare but I survived each time and felt glad that it was over afterward so I'd do it again just to have that feeling of relief once the ordeal was over-

Kids can be strange creatures that perform odd rituals- some times cruel and sadistic for little to no good reason- childhood can be a bizarre place for some- especially in an unsupervised childhood-

Our elementary school bathrooms were a place you only went into if you absolutely needed to- peeing your pants might be a better fate than what befell some children in those elementary school bathrooms-

Walking past the water fountain with all the fountain heads broken off- tiny pulses of water would pump out of the broken pipes in which you had to heavily slurp to get any water out of- you were lucky if you could drink water at all and not pee as before you took a drink a child would come by and tap on each broken faucet saying "coffee, tea, milkshake, pee" if you got pee you would move over to the adjacent faucet to be rewarded with coffee or milkshake-

It was all the same water coming out of rusty pipes with bright green algae growing on them- you might actually get real pee no matter which you would choose as kids were often caught standing on the water fountain peeing into it- perhaps they partook in this brazen act to avoid the horrors of the children's restroom with its miniature urinals of terror.

The broken faucets did have some advantages though as you could stick your finger in them and if you used the right amount of pressure you could fire a stream of water 15-20 feet at a passerby- or the kid drinking water next to you. This was all fun and games but the boys restroom was not fun and games- it was a place of nightmares- blood curdling screams- odd sights and some times no escape-

No escape-

It felt like there was no escape in those dark Chuck E. Cheese tunnels for awhile when you were in there- I don't even know if that was a real place for kids to play- it might have just been some utility tunnel to work on the animatronics that some kid found- then another kid followed and so on- I don't really know what it was for or what was really going on in there- I just know that in the middle of it- it felt like you might never get out- just like the elementary school boys bathroom-

My experiences in the Chuck E. Cheese tunnel and in the elementary school bathrooms were nightmarish in the sense that I would imagine those scenes would appear in other peoples nightmares- I had nightmares of my own that there nothing like those experiences- my nightmares were real-

I remember hiding underneath the table at Chuck E. Cheese whenever the person wearing the purple monster costume playing “Mr. Munch” came near- I was terrified of that one and I didn’t know why- those people
in the plush suits were there for the children’s entertainment but they terrified me-

I sort of knew they were people in costumes but I still didn’t trust them- was it because I had already been in his Mad House and it was no wonderful place- it was called a mad house after all- so what can you expect- whose idea was it to have kids run through an unsupervised madhouse any way?

I would imagine a nightmare would be like this- its bright and sunny outside- you are in elementary school- you ask the teacher to go to the bathroom- you are walking towards the restroom- the school is peaceful and empty with everyone in class-

A child with a magnifying glass in hand stops you on your way to the bathroom “are you a real man“ he asks you “what “ you reply- “are you a real man“ they repeat- “I guess so” you answer- they grab your arm and hold the magnifying glass above it- you look at them then back down at your arm “ ow! “ you bark- your arm with a sharp pain where the hot pinpoint of light was focused “ You’re not a real man “ they say walking off-

You continue on towards the bathroom stopping at the doorway to look at the coffee, the tea, the milkshakes and yes- the pee- all is quiet so you duck inside the bathroom-

A wiggling something catches your eye from above- you look up and see a kid with his legs jammed against the wall "Spider-manning" he looks at you and giggles- thoroughly entertained by his Spiderman climbing of the yellow tile walls with a dull glaze-

You walk up to the urinal as a cacophony of giggles and screams tears into the bathroom-

You freeze up- clenching your fists and gasping as the door slams shut and the lights black out- you feel several bodies vibrating next to yours as you stand in front of the urinals- a large oxidized bathroom mirror spread out on the wall in front of you- you've seen this before- you know what is going to happen and you have to get out before it does-

The bodies vibrate faster and the cacophony of childish mischief and sadism begins to well up- louder- you push past the bodies and run underneath several spidermen who have climbed high up on the walls for safety from what is coming next-

You grasp the bathroom door handle and pull as hard as you can with a grunt- blocked from the other side as muffled laughter seeps through the dank wall- you pound upon the door as the muffled laughter grows- the chants begin- panicked- you look for a way out but there aren't any to be found-

You stand rigid pressed up against the door- your eyes firing left than firing right as you know they will be coming for you- the chants grow louder- you must get out now- you must escape before they grab you and she comes-

Time freezes as you gasp for air in the dark humid bathroom- your heart races as screams spike- then cries- “no! Noo!“ a boy screams “Noooo!” he cries out louder- they got him-

The chants grow louder- must get out before she comes- you pull on the door handle with all your strength to no avail- they are chanting- they are saying her name- louder and louder- the time is near- she is coming- you can feel it in the air with a sinister heaviness that makes it hard to breathe- you gasp and cry without gasping or crying- it just feels that way in your throat- you can’t make a sound at all as your tiny feet shuffle- moving you closer to the long wall that leads to the open area where the horror is happening- why are you doing this feet? why are you moving towards it?

What do you want to see? Why do you want to see it?

With your face pressed against the wall you slide along the cool damp tile- it feels good on your face as you can see tiny arms holding shoulders- the gleam of white teeth- open mouths- saliva flings with guttural screams- the voices chant in unison “Bloody Mary! Bloody Mary Bloody Mary” you know she will be here soon- as you watch- screaming- violence- terror- the light blasts on “what is going on in here” a stern adult voice yells out- the children scatter and hustle out of the bright bathroom like cockroaches running for cover in your neighbors disgusting kitchen-

You stand and watch as a lone boy remains- on his knees sobbing- you stand and watch- an invisible observer- the boy turns- tears gleaming in his red eyes hands pressed against face-

He pulls his hands away from his face and you see bloody red scratches from tiny fingers lengthwise down his face- he sobs as you watch him being carried away by a man in an apron-

The boy wasn't you- but this boy had worn a paper mask on Halloween- you think of the children's faces- the children who did this to him- you know that they wear masks every day of the year except for Halloween- and you will not pity them when their time comes-

LETS THROW DEAD SNAKES AT KIDS

I was an odd child in elementary school-

For example while on a camping trip with my sisters girl scout troop one weekend- I found a dead gopher snake on the side of the road- I was fascinated by snakes and that was the first real one I had come across it just happened to be dead-

I didn't care if it was dead- so I took it home and hid it in our family freezer- when Monday came around I took it to school hidden in a paper bag- when I got to school in the morning I hid it in my desk-

When recess came I took the bag out into the school yard- removed the snake from the bag then proceeded to throw the dead, bloody snake at any child that I could-

I focused on the ones that screamed and cried the most- it was great fun terrifying the other kids with the dead snake- when recess was over I returned it to the desk- when school was over I put it back in the freezer and repeated this process for 2 or 3 school days before a teacher caught me and took the snake away-

I would often be found walking around the neighborhood with a living toad in hand- an older boy that lived across the street named Terri had gone to a more rural part of California and come back with some toads that he set free in our backyard so they became my pets-

People were afraid of the Toads because they wrongly believed that Toads gave people warts- these sorts of behaviors didn't make me many friends besides one of my best friends Carlos who died a few years ago from a genetic illness- his family was extremely poor- he has three brothers and three

sisters- an uneducated mother and a dad that was in jail for being a gang member and PCP fiend-

At the advanced age of 8 Carlos knew his way around paid phone sex lines- he asked me one day “What’s your favorite one on 976-WETT?”

I remember seeing the number with an image of a woman slick lips that could be found on paper matchbooks littering the ground around liquor stores “ what” I asked having never called 976-WETT as an eight or eighteen year old “ I like number 3 and number 5- those are the best “ he assured me-

He also told me out of the blue that his brother had a cork in is butt- and that his mom had to pull it out to let him poop then she put it back in- My young autistic mind often wandered to thoughts of his brother and his cork- How do they know when to pull it out? Who put it in there? Does it ever shoot out like a pirates pop gun?

One of my fondest childhood memories with Carlos was spending the night at his house drinking Kool Aid and watching one of the Police Academy movies- he liked that it had boobies as he was an expert at that time- I liked the guy who made all the sounds-

I brought a Toad with me that night- it peed all over my hand as they often did out of fear so I think I called my mom to come take me home so I could put the toad back in the yard-

I had a problem sleeping over at my friends houses- once everyone was asleep I’d get scared and ask to go home- one of those times I was at Skeletor house- everyone called him Skeletor based on a cartoon but I called him Jeffy- his mom was the fattest person I knew at the time-

I was always amazed at the massive size of her ass- maybe because his dad was tiny- a tiny skinny man with a little voice- I was perplexed seeing this tiny skinny man with the fattest woman in the world with a giant ass-

I imagined him getting trapped in it and dying a terrible death- screaming out for help- the woman turning- going “what” while he suffocated.

She drove a school bus- a few times she let us ride with her as she returned the bus to the bus graveyard- a big cement place fenced in with barbed wire- a huge parking lot full of empty school buses-

As she filled out paperwork we’d explore the empty buses- it was dark now and it felt strange to be inside these empty buses filled with shadows- the wind howled through the half open doors- we would sit and talk and play- jumping from seat to seat until his mom called for us-

SOMEONE TELL ME TO COVER MY EYES

I saw a naked lady in a movie for the first time at Jeffy's house- he lived next door so I could stay at his house really late- he had a teenage sister who smoked because you could always smell smoke on her- smoke and hairspray- large pink Aquanet bottles towered above everything else in their bathroom-

One Friday night his mom took us to the local video store- back when mom and pop VHS video stores were everywhere- you'd wander in staring at the covers trying to sneak into the adults only area with naked ladies- well actually you could just walk right in there-

I was afraid so I never did- but Jeffy did- later he would tell me the glory of the boobies he saw- his mom would let us rent a movie or two and his teenage sister picked the rest-

His mom let us rent anything we wanted- we were 7 or 8 and R rated movies were fine but as we were watching we had to cover our eyes when she told us too- I always did what she said- so when the time came and she would say " ok cover your eyes boys " I would do it using my imagination while listening to the sounds wondering what was happening- then she'd say " ok you can uncover them now " and I'd be allowed to watch again-

Later in the night as we were watching another R rated movie- I think it was Purple Rain because his sister was in love with Prince as many a teenage girls was at that time- so I'm watching this movie and I can sense that a "naughty" part was coming- something I'm not supposed to see- in a panic because no one has told me to cover my eyes I look over at his mom- snoring- asleep- I look over at his sister- asleep- I look over at Jeffy- his eyes beaming- awake- alive-

I slowly turn my head back towards the glowing TV screen- I'm not supposed to be seeing this?! What is going to happen to me? I was nervous- expecting his mom to wake up at any time and slap me across the face for being such a bad boy- it was the part in Purple Rain where Prince dares a woman to jump into a lake- so as I was watching with my illegal kid eyeballs as she took her shirt off and I saw boobies-

I looked back at Jeffy as he nodded his head in approval- we watched the rest of the movie alone- I don't remember much else that happened in that film as it didn't make much sense to an 8 year old me- It was a very confusing night for me with the films I was allowed to watch- after Purple Rain we watched a horror movie called Mausoleum- in the end a naked lady rises out of a bath tub and crushes a man to death in her arms- good stuff for the 8 year old mind to prepare him for future relationships with women-

THE FOAM CLUB

Bobby and I together were little punk bastards- here's some of the many things we did routinely what would have gotten us arrested today-

This was shortly after the Rodney King police beating videos had been released- everyone had seen those punk cops beating that man to a pulp with their black police batons out in the middle of some street-

Bobby lived right in front of a busy one way street- we were always looking for ways to troll the traffic like punk kids do-

Once a month we would get to go to the local flea market where you could buy all sorts of crap toys-

Bobby bought a black police baton- it was shiny polyester on the outside- it really looked like wood- and the inside was made out of foam- because of these materials you could swing it really fast and hit someone really hard yet it didn't hurt at all but it made a loud WHAP- so it looked and sounded like you were beating the hell out of someone when you hit them with it- but it was harmless-

Bobby had a little brother that was about 5 when we were 10 years old- the little brother and I were often a team fighting against Bobby as he a lot stronger than us- so his little brother was usually my ally- other times I watched helplessly as he got the "figure-four!" or the "Human torture rack"

Tonight Bobby had a great plan he didn't share with me- so I got to watch it unfold- I was standing on the sidewalk next to the busy street- Bobby told me to stand out there and signal him when the surge of cars was coming down the street- I

didn't want to get caught in a figure-four he so masterfully applied so I complied-

The cars started to come down the street so I signaled him by waving my arms- his little brother busted out the front door yelling " no no no!" with a kick in the butt from Bobby.

Bobby with the foam police baton in chase- just as his little brother got to the sidewalk and just as the cars were beginning to whip by- Bobby pushed the kid to the floor and began wailing on him with the baton WHAP WHAP WHAP the drivers slowed to a crawl- faces a gasp- watching in horror as this little boy was clubbed right there on the sidewalk in front of them WHAP WHAP WHAP "no no no" his brother screamed-

Drivers yelled out from their cars to try to stop the madness but we're unable to stop in the fast moving one way street- WHAP WHAP WHAP all the while Bobby yelled out-

This was probably influenced by calling out pro wrestling moves because as he beat his brother in front of those shocked faces he yelled out "Rodney King Rodney King" So as these shocked motorists looked on- this ten year old was clubbing this little kid with a police baton WHAP WHAP WHAP whilst yelling "Rodney King Rodney King" in his best white guy police officer voice- we saw some of the cars stopping up the street- the drivers running over towards us so we ran in the apartment-locked the door and laughed- unsupervised punk kids-

Bobby's brother knew to sell the gag as he was supposed to yell "no" and pretend to be upset and pretend to cry which he did- he was a tough little kid- we were always wrestling with him and punching him and he never cried- he ended up becoming a medical doctor- no joke.

So as random things tended to happen when we were playing unsupervised by adults- Bobby's little brother and myself were fighting Bobby as we often did- two against one and he still always beat us- well now he was chasing around the apartments with a raw hot dog in his hand- holding the floppy hot dog in his hand threatening to throw it- we ran from him screaming-

I was pretending to be scared as I was a gross kid so I wasn't scared of a raw hotdog- I thought his little brother was pretending to be scared too- he chased us past the garage and through a gate- I opened the gate and ran through as his brother followed me-

I can remember this moment in slow motion- the gate was closing as his brother ran toward me with real terror in is eyes- at the last moment Bobby flicked the floppy hot dog and it spun toward his brother flipping end over end-

The hotdog flipped through the open gate at the last possible moment and with a dull WHAP it hit his brother on his shoulder- the shiny limp hotdog fell into the dirt-

Like he had just been hit by a sniper's 50 caliber round his brother dropped to the ground grabbing his shoulder crying- really crying- I stopped and looked down at his brother- Bobby stopped being the scary man and walked up to him too as snot bubbles and tears screamed out of his face-

Bobby and I looked at each other shocked " Why are you crying?" Bobby asked " You hit me with the weenie" his brother sobbed " Did it hurt? Did you get hurt " Bobby asked " No " his brother barked " Then why are you crying- I was beating you up all day but you didn't cry and now your crying" Bobby asked " You hit me with a weenie! " his brother said sobbing-

Bobby and I looked at each other not knowing what to say but wanting to laugh “A weeeeeeenieeeee!” his brother screamed sobbing- “A WEEEENIEEEEE”

SUPER GIRL SCOUTS

Ever since I came across a “Boy’s Life” magazine as a six or seven year old I really wanted to be a Boy Scout. I loved the outdoors and the stuff in those magazines looked like a lot of fun. My mom tried to get me in a Boy Scout troop. There was a really well organized one but apparently- it was for Japanese kids only-

Since I wasn’t asian looking enough and since none of us had dad’s to run a Boy Scout troop- the boys in my neighborhood had no Boy Scouts- shit, my friends and I- the hella bad boys were probably the closest thing to the Boy Scout’s around-

We just fished for cockroaches instead of fish- we just made pipe bombs instead of bonfires- we went and talked to the local bum’s instead of scout leader Bob-

Since there were a lot of Mom’s around the local Girl Scout troops were strong- they got to do all kinds of fun stuff- My sister was in the girl scouts and my mom was one of the den mothers-

So when I was nine or ten years old I was a tough boy so I thought- I hated girls- being around girls was the worst thing a tough boy could do. Since my dad was hardly ever around and/or in a state to take care of me- whenever the girl scouts had camping trips or Jamboree’s I had to go-

Against his will this bad kid had to be an honorary Girl Scout- I loathed it- I was the only boy ever there-

I remember hiding in the tent as they sang songs and laughed and had fun- and I just stayed in the tent reading a book or playing with action figures-

Or I would just go off into the forest on my own and wander around looking for dead snakes I could take home and throw at people at school.

A bad kid almost died one Jamboree night- almost died from exposure to girl scout spirit.

The girl scout troop had a talent show of sorts so they were singing songs or acting out skits or in the near death experience- rapping.

I remember sitting in that tent cringing- and rolling over and over trying to sleep- being kept awake with their giggling and their girl scout spirit- I didn't even have any girl scout cookies to help smooth the experience out.

The performance that almost killed a young bad kid was of a few girl scouts performing of the rap song by "J.J. Fad"- the song was called "SuperSonic" but they changed it so be "SuperGirlScouts"

The song went through every letter of supersonic like- the s is for super- the u is for unique- the p is for pretty and so on-

The evil girl scouts changed it to like girl scouty things- it was terrible- my sister was one of rappers- something I teased her about for years-

I had survived the experience and the girl scouts had gone to sleep- I had to find some kind of evidence or artifact to

show Bobby- to prove to him that I had heard the lamest thing ever-

Once all the girl scouts went to sleep I creeped around the campfire- I found a few wrinkled sheets of yellow binder paper that read “SUPER GIRL SCOUTS” at the top. It was the song lyrics- I found it!

When I got back home and showed it to Bobby- we laughed and laughed.

If I ever wanted to piss my sister off I would just start rapping Super Girl Scouts.

I’m sure a big part of my hatred of the Girl Scouts was out of jealousy- I wanted to be a Boy Scout- but there weren’t any in my neighborhood- that would accept me.

Thanks Dad’s.

DUMPSTER BASEBALL LEAGUE

There weren't any Boy Scout troops in our neighborhood but there were plenty of little league baseball teams. Since I started late playing baseball I didn't play on any teams until I was 13.

Bobby and I joined this shitty "Senior" little league team- it was for ages 13-15. The main baseball fields backstop had a giant dumpster right behind so it always stunk like trash on the field.

I swear because of the calls they made and because of the way they looked they got the fucking umpires for that league out of that dumpster- they were all like crazy hobo's making ridiculous calls- you never knew what was a ball or a strike for what they would call you out for.

You didn't have to show your birth certificate to prove your age so there were kids that were obviously older than others out there- a couple had tattoo's and lots of facial hair.

Me- I was a skinny thirteen year old that had never played on a baseball team before- the pants felt too tight- I had to wear this weird cup thing- we had to be there at 7am on Saturdays- but that all wasn't that bad-

So since I had never played on a team I was new to the whole baseball etiquette thing-

The first game of the season I was scheduled to pitch- I like pitching and I was looking forward to it- Before the first inning started I went up to the mound and threw my warmup pitches- I felt ok and was beginning to get more comfortable when our coach came out to talk to me.

He was really young for a baseball coach- 21 at the time. He had just given up on his own baseball career and told us that the reason he coached our team is because telling girls he was a kids coach was an easy way to get chicks.

So he comes up to the mound before the game starts and reminds me of things to do- I'm ok at that point- then as he's leaving he slaps me on my butt in those super tight pants really hard- I froze up-

I'm 13- puberty is brand new- I'm a man right? I like girls right? Am I gay now? Does everyone thing I'm gay? AM I GAY NOW?! I don't think I want to be gay?!

What the fuck baseball I just wanted to throw the ball and hit the ball- wait a minute?! Does this hard ball in my hand represent a man's hard balls?! Is this whole thing a big gay sex ritual that I didn't know about?! Oh my god?!

"Why did he just touch my butt in front of all these people?!" I thought- I didn't know what was going on- my butt stinging with this gay assault I had just been a victim off in front of this crowd that didn't seem to care?!

I didn't know about the whole baseball ass slapping thing as no one had done it to me before and I couldn't process what just happened-

I was lost in my own head and I played terribly- I was like a zombie just going through motions- mind disconnected from body- I embarrassed myself with my play and felt like a failure as my mom was watching- Bobby's mom was watching and I failed- and this man did this butt thing- why did he do that?

I still don't know why men slap other men's asses in the game of baseball-how did that get started?

Do they kick each others dicks in the showers?

Do hey head butt each others balls in the dugout?

I mean where does this touchy feely grabby stuff end- and why did it start?

I don’t want to know- I lost my interest in baseball many years ago-

PAPER MASKS GO AROUND THE SILENT CIRCLE

The elementary school I attended was an average public school in a lower middle class neighborhood- for Halloween our big deal was when the faculty would place a record player in the middle of the schoolyard then all the kids in costume would walk around in a circle around the record player as it played Halloween music-

I was lucky enough that my mom made sure I had a costume every year- one year I was a Centurion- another year a Star Wars Hero- I remember the sadness I felt as a child in the classroom just before we all departed to go outside and prance around the old brown record player-

There were kids whose parents didn't get them a costume- either because they were too poor or maybe they just forgot- there were some really poor kids in the school- one of my friends used to show me a fun game in the kitchen of his house- we'd walk into the kitchen when the lights were off then flick them on and hordes of big brown cockroaches would scatter and hide in the cabinets-

He did another trick wherein he pulled out a box of cereal and poured some into a bowl- cockroaches rushed out of the cereal box- he laughed before opening the fridge- getting out a carton of milk- pouring it onto the cereal and eating it with a large dirty spoon-

This halloween circle was supposed to be a fun time but it was often a silent and sad one- the scratchy music from an old record skipped- a teacher rushing over to fix it missing a few beats- no one said a word- the sound of tiny shoes and rustling vinyl costumes was all that could be heard along with the scratchy song-

So some of the poor kids didn't have costumes- or some of the kids with shitty parents- or parents that didn't think it was important for their kids to have a five dollar vinyl costume-

As the kids without costumes waited in awkward silence as they were holding up the fun time Halloween parade- I looked around the room- the kids with costumes didn't seem to notice what was going on but I did-

It was required for all the kids to "have fun" and be a part of the parade to nowhere- but they didn't have costumes- instead of being left out something had to be found to allow them to fit in and be a part of the "fun"-

I remember looking at them and feeling bad- not really because of the lack of a costume but because in one way or another their parents had failed them- I felt lucky that my mom cared about me enough to get me a cool costume of Batman or whoever-

The teacher dug into a drawer in a place where teachers keep things away from the prying hands of 8 year old children-

She returned with a few paper masks for the children without costumes- dropping them onto the desk- I stared at them-

Nothing any child would be excited about- no Transformers, no Luke Skywalker, no mummies, just generic cartoon animal faces-

Characters some underpaid illustrator made as an addition to kids picture book about a duck that could or couldn't-

Or a cat that got lost or a bird that ate too much-

A side dish from a main course of childish mediocrity served up because they had to fill a demographic that needed books-

School boards, districts and teachers that only looked forward to Friday not adding a tiny bit of magic that could have been had with ten cents of glitter and twenty cents of glue and feathers. An extra hour to make something nice for these kids that were left out- not they didn't do that-

They were just some generic cutout animal faces for kids whose parents had let them down-

It still makes me sad thinking about the look in the eyes of those kids- their gaze darting about the room as all of us with our costumes waited on them- looking at them with our shiny plastic masks as they were handed a paper consolation costume by a teacher that was just there for a paycheck.

They put the generic paper masks on and dipped their heads- craned their necks down like adults do today with their smart phones to avoid their physical reality-

Except they had nothing to look at but the faded white lines on blue grey concrete of a deteriorating schoolyard in a neighborhood filled with adults that just told then what they couldn't do.

Why wouldn't you want to be bad?

I guess its over now-

Thanks for reading some of my hella bad boy stories.

This text is intentional.

Sincerely and hella toughly,

M dot Strange (Michael)